



KERALA BUDGET

UDF govt. outlines  
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Burnham's win spells  
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the knockout round

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INSIDE

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Israel, Hezbollah  
to 'halt fighting'  
in South Lebanon

**JERUSALEM**  
Israel and the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group agreed on Friday to halt the heavy fighting in southern Lebanon that had threatened to unravel an interim agreement between the United States and Iran to end their war, officials said. Neither Israel nor Hezbollah immediately confirmed the truce. » **PAGE 12**

3-language policy  
is not viable, say  
Nagaland schools

**NEW DELHI**  
Principals from Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) affiliated schools in Nagaland have written to Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan conveying their difficulty in implementing the compulsory three-language policy framework, including introduction of Sanskrit, in Naga schools. » **PAGE 3**

Uddhav offers  
to step down as  
Sena (UBT) chief

**MUMBAI**  
In an emotional appeal to his party leaders and cadres on the 60<sup>th</sup> foundation day of the united Shiv Sena on Friday, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray offered to step down as the party's president if they believed in the allegations levelled against him by the defected MPs. » **PAGE 4**

HC upholds curbs on Telegram amid NEET row

The definition of 'information' in IT Act includes software and programmes, says Delhi High Court

Centre followed Section 69A of IT Act and gave reasons for using emergency powers, says court

Centre's pleas that channel-specific takedowns on Telegram had failed were accepted by the HC

**Ishita Mishra**  
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Friday upheld the Centre's temporary ban on messaging platform Telegram, noting that the government's action was proportionate and justified in view of the alleged use of the platform by organised cheating networks linked to the NEET (UG), 2026, controversy. Dismissing Telegram's challenge to the June 16 emergency blocking order, the court found that the Union government had followed the procedure prescribed under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act and had record-

ed adequate reasons for invoking its emergency powers. A significant aspect of the ruling is the court's endorsement of the government's interpretation of Section 69A. 'Entire platform' Rejecting Telegram's argument that the provision permits blocking only specific content and not an entire platform, the court held that the Act's broad definition of "information" encompasses software and computer programmes. Since Telegram functions through software infrastructure constituting a "computer resource", the government was legally empowered to direct a

Court's endorsement

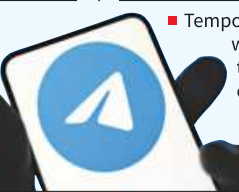
What the Delhi High Court said in the Telegram case

Centre empowered under Section 69A of the IT Act to restrict 'entire platform' access

Centre has cited circulation of purported examination papers and fraudulent activities targeting students as reason

Govt. order not disproportionate as attempts to resolve through channel-specific takedowns failed

Temporary restrictions were proportionate to the objective of preventing misinformation and criminal activity



temporary block on the platform, the court said. "An application or platform performs logical, arithmetic and memory functions through electronic, magnetic or optical impulses, and includes input, output, processing,

issue directions for blocking public access to Telegram," it said. The court rejected Telegram's contention that the order reflected non-application of mind. The court observed that the government had specifically cited the circulation of purported examination papers, fraudulent activities targeting students and the inability of existing measures to curb recurring violations. Accepting the Centre's argument that repeated attempts to tackle the problem through channel-specific takedowns on Telegram had failed, the court said, "The government's measures are least restrictive. It cannot be

held that the order is disproportionate." According to material placed before the government, operators of fraudulent networks were routinely creating mirror channels, backup groups and successor accounts after enforcement action, rendering targeted removals ineffective, the court said. The judgment noted that authorities had concluded that "nothing short of a platform-level measure" would protect the integrity of the examination during the critical period preceding the June 21 re-test. Telegram had argued that it was being unfairly singled out while other social media platforms conti-

nued to operate. The company told the court that it had cooperated with authorities, removed flagged content within hours, and had taken down over 900 links related to unlawful NEET content using a combination of artificial intelligence tools and manual moderation. However, the court held that the emergent circumstances surrounding the NEET-UG controversy justified the government's intervention and that the temporary restrictions were proportionate to the objective of preventing misinformation and criminal activity. **RELATED REPORT ON » PAGE 3**

Still waters, calm minds



A yoga session under way on Pokhribal Lake in Srinagar on Friday, in the run-up to International Yoga Day observed on June 21. IMRAN NISSAR

Walking on footpath is a  
fundamental right, says SC

**Krishnadas Rajagopal**  
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday, in a judgment, declared the freedom to walk on demarcated and well-maintained footpaths a fundamental right which has priority over movement by motorised vehicles. The court highlighted the need to lay down a statutory framework, not only for declaring the right to walk a fundamental right, but also to recognise the duty-bearers. "If a road exists, there must then be a duty to ensure that a footpath is demarcated and maintained for the walkers. This is an enforceable duty... Walking is not just motion, it embodies expressional, congregational and associational rights under Article 19



If a road exists, there must then be a duty to ensure that a footpath is demarcated and maintained for the walkers. This is an enforceable duty... Walking is not just motion, it embodies expressional, congregational and associational rights under Article 19



SUPREME COURT

little space for walking, the court said. "It could also be elitism to start with, for machines with wheels were only for the rich, but as economies progressed and cheaper motor vehicles were introduced, the entire spectrum of motorised transportation dominated the roads, pushed aside the walkers to the extent that they are treated as a nuisance for the drivers who routinely run over the walkers and their footpaths. This should stop from now on as we declare the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths alongside motorised roads," the top court said. "Walking is a struggle for the not-so-fortunate, meditation in motion for many, resistance for others, discovery for the inquisitive, a cohesive strategy for sharp socio-political minds. It certainly did inspire and ignite some of the ideals of the freedom struggle... In that sense, walking is not just motion, it certainly embodies expressional, congregational and associational rights under Article 19(1)(a), Article 19(1)(b) and Article 19(1)(c)," Justice Narasimha said. Common spaces must not be the monopoly of motorised vehicles. The freedom to walk, subject to reasonable restrictions, also deserved ample space. "In reality, how much does it take to create a well-demarcated footpath wherever a road exists? All that the fundamental right to walk demands is a comfortable space for an easy and carefree walk. Should this not be the minimum of the minimum duty that a municipal authority owes to the citizens?" the top court asked the government. **Regulatory body** It said that the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, had never bothered to recognise the fundamental right to walk. The Supreme Court also highlighted that the proposed Act must protect, enhance, and provide quick remedies for violations, and also establish a full-time regulator to plan, enforce, and implement the right to walk. "To enhance and effectuate the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths, it is necessary to establish a regulatory body... Institutional expertise is critical, and such a regulator will employ human resources with domain expertise and talent," Justice Narasimha said. The court directed its Registry to send a copy of the judgment to the Ministries of Housing and Urban Affairs, Rural Development, Road Transport and Highways, to "reflect on the compelling necessity for initiating the necessary legal framework". The Justice also said Constitutional courts were also obliged to declare and reiterate the right to walk as a fundamental right. **EDITORIAL: RIGHT OF WAY » PAGE 6**

Soon, police may scan your fingerprints on the go

**Vijaita Singh**  
NEW DELHI

Police and investigating agencies across the country will soon be equipped with portable fingerprint scanners linked to a national database of 1.3 crore criminal suspects and convicts, letting them stop individuals anywhere, even on the streets, to collect thumb impressions and instantly check for any pending criminal records on their smartphones. Abhigyan, an app developed by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) to implement the procedure, was launched by Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday. The app links to the National Automated Fingerprint Identification System (NAFIS), which stores fingerprint scans of accused, convicts, and those in prisons. A demonstration of the app showed that prints can

be matched with the NAFIS database in 35 seconds. "During routine vehicle checks on the streets, biometric scans of any suspicious individual can be conducted to identify persons wanted in connection with crimes. Field officers can get the criminal history of the suspect in few seconds. This will provide protection to the police as they will be alerted of the presence of a hardened criminal," the demo stated. An NCRB official told *The Hindu* that the Criminal Procedure Identification Act, 2022 provides the legal basis for such checks. However, Section 3 of the Act seems to limit the mandatory recording of measurements, including fingerprints, to people who have been convicted or arrested, and those ordered to give security for good behaviour or maintaining peace under the Code of Criminal Procedure, 1973. The Act does not men-



**Data patrol:** The app enables field police personnel to access a vast repository of criminal records directly on their smartphones. PTI

tion the possibility of random testing of individuals without any evidence linking them to a punishable offence. **Current system** At present, the facility to check fingerprints against the NAFIS database is only available through 1,556 workstations deployed at police stations and district headquarters across the country. The current process involves bringing an individual to the workstation to match his or her fingerprints with the database. Mr. Shah said that the app enables field police personnel to access a vast repository of criminal records directly on their smartphones. "Secured with two-step authentication, it allows real-time fingerprint identification within seconds, strengthening ground-level policing. Equipped with fea-

tures such as fast identification, portability, and access to millions of records, 'Abhigyan' is a highly powerful tool," the Minister said. The NAFIS database includes the records of around 9.91 lakh narcotics offenders, 3.65 lakh human trafficking cases, and extensive prison databases, Mr. Shah said. NAFIS should not be used merely to identify offenders, he said, noting that its effectiveness depends on continuously enriching the database by uploading fingerprints collected from every crime scene. He noted that a criminal's DNA sample, if properly preserved, can also be used in the investigation of other crimes, adding that this is primarily the responsibility of the States. The focus should not be limited merely to the arrest of criminals but on time-bound justice, the Home Minister said added.

INBRIEF



New spice plant to benefit 5,500 farmers in Meghalaya

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday inaugurated the largest organic spice processing plant in northeast India at Lumdaitkhla in Meghalaya’s Ri-Bhoi district. Established by the Eastern Ri-Bhoi Organic Farmer Producer Company, the facility has an annual processing capacity of 10,000 metric tonnes. It is expected to directly benefit around 5,500 organic farmers. The unit is equipped to process turmeric, black pepper, and many other spices. Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma and his Sikkim counterpart Prem Singh Tamang attended the inauguration ceremony.

Eight killed in lightning strikes across Jharkhand

At least eight people, including two women and a two-year-old boy, were killed in lightning strikes across six districts of Jharkhand, police said on Friday. Of the eight people, three were killed in Hazaribag district, an official said. A 30-year-old woman was killed in Manhar village in Palamu. In Ramgarh’s Pipratand village, a 15-year-old girl died after lightning struck her while she was grazing goats. In Lohardaga, a 13-year-old girl was killed while she was plucking mangoes from a tree. A 30-year-old man was also killed by a lightning strike in the Godda district. In West Singhbhum, a two-year-old boy died, and his mother suffered serious burn injuries, officials said.

Ram Temple donation row: truth will come out in SIT investigation, says Adityanath

Mayank Kumar  
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said on Friday that truth will prevail through the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probe into the issue of alleged ‘missing donations’ in Ram Temple trust and appealed to political parties to refrain from making baseless comments until the investigation is complete.

“Anyone in possession of documentary evidence is encouraged to present it to the SIT,” said Mr. Adityanath while addressing a public gathering in Ayodhya, following the inauguration and laying of foundation stones for 126 projects worth over ₹378 crore.

The Chief Minister urged the devotees of Lord Ram not to be misled by those attempting to tarnish the



Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath during the inauguration of the ‘Ramayana Wax Museum’ in Ayodhya on Friday.

reputation of Ayodhya and the Ram Temple.

Opposition criticised

Hitting out at the Opposition parties, Mr. Adityanath cautioned people that those who failed to provide electricity to Ayodhya and kept it confined to narrow lanes are now spreading misinformation and making malicious attempts to insult Ayodhya.

Directly questioning the Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, the Chief Minister said, “He (Akhilesh Yadav) who has not yet visited the Ram Mandir and had also prevented his MLAs from visiting Ayodhya, is now making motivated remarks to defame the temple. Their devotion is not towards Ram; they are people who worship Babur.”

Uproar over defacing of Ambedkar’s statue in U.P.

Mayank Kumar  
LUCKNOW

Jajouli and adjoining villages in U.P.’s Kaushambi district were on the edge on Friday, after a statue of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar was vandalised by miscreants late on Thursday. The villagers, who are mostly Dalits, held a sit-in protest at the site. They raised slogans and demanded the strictest action against the culprits.

Police helped reinstall the statue and persuaded demonstrators to end their protests after promising action and assuring there would be no repeat of such an incident. A significant number of policemen are still stationed in the area.

Maker of *Battlefield* says film is very much related to present-day conflict in Manipur

The Hindu Bureau  
GUWAHATI

An anti-war documentary from the ethnic conflict-scarred Manipur is set to be screened at the ongoing 19th Mumbai International Film Festival (MIFF) on Saturday.

The seven-day MIFF, South Asia’s oldest and largest festival dedicated to documentary, short fiction, and animation films, ends on Sunday.

Manipuri filmmaker Borun Thokchom’s *Battlefield*, an 80-minute documentary that revisits the battles of Imphal and Kohima during World War II, took 13 years to complete. Another film from Manipur, Trishul Yumnam and Yaso Sharma’s 15-minute anima-



A scene from Borun Thokchom’s Battlefield. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tion *Story of a Forest*, has also made it to MIFF’s international competition.

Present-day Manipur and Nagaland were theatres of World War II in 1944. Fought between the Allied forces and the Imperial Japanese Army alongside Subhash Chandra Bose’s Indian National Army, the battles named after the State capitals are considered a turning point in the

war in Asia. Locals, however, continue to feel the impact of the battles.

“World War II turned Manipur into a frontline battlefield. Villages were bombed, people were displaced, and locals watched big foreign armies fight for their own freedom. That experience gave people new ideas about self-rule and nationhood,” Mr. Thok-

chom told *The Hindu*.

“Soon after the war, Manipur was merged with India. The destruction caused by the war and that forced merger left behind a deep anger, and that anger grew into the ethnic and separatist movements that have lasted ever since,” he said.

Ethnic violence

*Battlefield* was almost complete when the ethnic violence between the Meitei and the Kuki-Zo communities erupted in Manipur on May 3, 2023. It eventually qualified for MIFF 2026.

Mr. Thokchom said the subject of his documentary may be a war fought eight decades ago, but “it is very much related” to the present-day conflict in Manipur.

tal clearances, to the project.

SC judgment

The CWDT and the Supreme Court have observed that the Cauvery basin is a deficit basin, and the total available water has already been apportioned among the basin States. Hence, no new project can be undertaken in the Cauvery basin, it said.

“The Cauvery issue is a

highly sensitive matter between Tamil Nadu and Karnataka,” the resolution said.

It urged the Centre to advise Karnataka government not to build any new water storage project at Mekedatu or any location in the Cauvery basin without the approval of the other basin States.

“As requested in the Tamil Nadu government’s letter on March 4, 2026, this

House urges the Union government to constitute a new Tribunal under Section 4 of the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956,” the resolution read.

‘Don’t approve DPR’

The resolution also urged the Central Water Commission (CWC) not to examine, process, or grant approval to the Detailed Project Report submitted by the Karnataka government.



T.N. CM Joseph C. Vijay moving a resolution in the House against the project on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Taking part in Yoga Day not mandatory, Bengal govt. tells HC

The Hindu Bureau  
KOLKATA

The Calcutta High Court on Friday disposed of a petition challenging a notification issued by the West Bengal government asking all the State government employees to participate in the official event of International Yoga Day on Sunday, after the State told the court that it was “not mandatory”.

While disposing of the petition represented by the senior Advocate Bikas Ranjan Bhattacharya, a single Bench court of Justice Amrita Sinha, noted the State’s clarification by the Additional Advocate General Bilwadal Bhattacharya.

“Written instruction forwarded by the OSD and Undersecretary to the Government of West Bengal dated June 14, 2026 is a general appeal to all public servants to participate in the official function on the occasion of International Day of Yoga. The above order is not mandatory in nature and no punitive or coercive action is either contemplated or incorporated in the order in case of failure to attend due to personal reasons,” read the copy of the final judgement.

Considering the clarification by the State govern-



CM Suvendu Adhikari at a yoga event in Kolkata on Friday. ANI

ment, the High Court concluded, “The Court is of the opinion that in view of the instruction forwarded by the respondent authority, there is no requirement of proceeding with the writ petition any further. The same stands disposed of.”

PM to attend session

Over 35,000 people will participate in the mass yoga demonstration session on International Yoga Day celebrations at Kolkata’s Red Road on June 21. The session will be led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

This will be the Prime Minister’s first visit to West Bengal since he attended Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari’s swearing-in after the Bharatiya Janta Party came to power in the State.

Police forced us to conduct last rites hurriedly, say Delhi house help’s kin

Shrimansi Kaushik  
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Friday remanded Dr. Manish Gupta, the dermatologist accused of murdering his domestic help, in police custody for two days.

The 56-year-old doctor was arrested the previous day from his home in East of Kailash for the murder of Mina Halder, 58.

Halder’s body was handed over to her family on Friday following an autopsy, the results of which are awaited. She was cremated shortly after.

The family alleged that, even as they were waiting for the deceased’s daughter and husband to arrive from Kolkata, the police forced them to perform the last rites hurriedly. “The police told us to take the body straight to the cremation ground. We weren’t allowed to keep the body even for a minute at



Delhi Police personnel outside the crime scene on Thursday. PTI

home,” Saptami Bishwas, a relative, told *The Hindu*.

Police deny charges

When reached for comment, the police denied the allegation.

Arguing for his custody before Judicial Magistrate Anurag Chhabra, the police sought the accused’s custody, contending that they need to investigate whether other people are

also involved in the murder and to unearth new facts in the case. “We had asked for his custody to interrogate him and look into all the aspects of the crime, including whether it was planned or committed on the spur of the moment,” said Deputy Commissioner of Police (South East) Hemant Tiwari.

Opposing the plea, the defence counsel argued,

“Everything has been seized by the police. He has been in police custody for the last 24 hours. He is already suffering from depression, and is a well-reputed doctor.”

Mr. Chhabra allowed the police’s plea. “The accused has been on medication for various psychological disorders, including OCD [obsessive compulsive disorder] and depression, for the past 20 years,” said the DCP.

Weapons recovered

The doctor was found sitting beside the victim’s body when a police team reached his house in Mount Kailash Apartments, the police said.

The accused has confessed to attacking his domestic help of 16 years with a bat and later stabbing her with a knife, and the weapons used in the crime have been recovered, the police also said.

NEET aspirant dies in Indore; probe under way, say police

Mehul Malpani  
BHOPAL

A 21-year-old female National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) aspirant died after falling from the house where she was living in Madhya Pradesh’s Indore, police said on Friday.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Indore Zone 4 DCP Sunil Kumar Mehta did not confirm suicide, saying Avantiika Maurya had died under “suspicious circumstances”. “The police have initiated an investigation,” he added. Her family said she had appeared for NEET-UG three times and the June 21 re-examination would have been her fourth attempt. “She had been disheartened by the recent question paper leak,” a family member added.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Kukis boarding flights from Imphal a positive sign, says CM

Rahul Karmakar  
GUWAHATI

Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh said on Friday that members of the Kuki community have started travelling to Imphal to board flights, which was a positive sign for the conflict-scarred State.

Since the ethnic conflict began on May 3, 2023, tribal Kuki-Zo and non-tribal Meiteis have avoided travelling to each other’s localities. While Meiteis dominate the Imphal Valley, where Manipur’s only airport is located, the Kuki-Zo people inhabit the surrounding hills.

Speaking at an official event in the tribal-dominated Tengenoupal district, Mr.



CM Yumnam Khemchand Singh inaugurating a girls’ hostel in Tengenoupal district on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Singh said a united Manipur was the only way forward for the 36 communities inhabiting the State.

“Manipur can progress only through unity, mutual respect, and peaceful coexistence. Development is possible only when people rise above community divi-

sions and work together with a shared identity,” he said.

Drawing a comparison with the diverse yet peaceful Singapore, he appealed to the people to safeguard the ongoing peace process for the benefit of future generations. He urged all sections of society to resolve differences through dialogue, pointing out that the State’s economy had suffered due to the violence.

‘Signs of normality’

He said signs of normality were however emerging after more than three years of conflict. “Many Kukis have started travelling to Imphal to board flights, and many groups have met me to discuss peace,” he said.

## 3-language policy not viable, say CBSE schools in Nagaland

# SC refuses urgent hearing on plea to defer NEET re-test

Earlier, the Bench led by Justice Narasimha had raised serious concerns over the cancellation of the examination , describing the development as “very traumatic”.

# Extraordinary level of opacity, says Congress leader on Nicobar project

The strategic rationale was no justification for opacity as everything that he sought “in no way comes in the way of fulfilling so-called strategic objectives”, Mr. Ramesh said.

# Pakistan is an example of a 'Frankenstein state', India says at UN

# Telangana govt. may withdraw funds from SBI over land row

# Palestine envoy seeks medical assistance for Gaza, West Bank

He said the Palestinian Ministry of Health currently needs to provide approximately 520 essential medicines to hospitals, but almost 180 of these drugs are “completely unavailable”. “Furthermore, out of 97 medicines specialised for cancer and tumour treatment, 50 are currently at zero stock levels, placing nearly 4,000 cancer patients at immediate risk,” he said.

Trinamool faces fresh exits, arrests in Bengal

**Shiv Sahay Singh**  
KOLKATA

Almost six weeks after facing defeat in the West Bengal Assembly election, desertions, resignations, and arrests of Trinamool Congress leaders continue in the State. On Friday, former West Bengal Minister Jyoti Priya Mallick, once known to be close to party chairperson Mamata Banerjee, resigned from the party, citing his failing health.

Another Trinamool leader, Narendranath Chakraborty, resigned from the post of district president of the party in Paschim Bardhaman district. Mr. Chakraborty wrote a letter to Trinamool State president informing her about his resignation due to failing health.

Gautam Deb, another close confidant of Ms. Banerjee and a prominent leader of north Bengal, resigned as the Mayor of Sili-guri Municipal Corpora-tion.

Meanwhile, former Tarakeswar MLA and Trinamool leader Ramendu Sinharoy was arrested by West Bengal Police in Karnataka. According to the police, he was evading authorities due to multiple allegations.

Rebel Trinamool MPs must be disqualified: Abhishek

Party leader urges Lok Sabha Speaker to decide on its disqualification petition at the earliest; he accuses the MPs of disrespecting the Constitution and betraying the mandate of the people

**Sobhana K. Nair**  
NEW DELHI

Trinamool Congress leader and national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Friday said the 20 Lok Sabha MPs elected on the party's ticket in the 2024 general election, who have now declared a merger with the little-known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), are liable for disqualification under the anti-defection law.

Mr. Banerjee said the party submitted all relevant Supreme Court judgments concerning the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and urged him to rule on the disqualification petition at the earliest.

"We presented all Supreme Court judgments concerning the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution to the Speaker. All cases are against them (the rebel group). They are claiming to be a separate group, they want one of them to be elected the Lok Sabha leader of NCPI, Chief Whip and so on. This



**Seeking action:** Trinamool Congress leaders Kalyan Banerjee, Abhishek Banerjee, Mahua Moitra leave after meeting Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, at the Parliament House complex, in New Delhi on Friday. PTI

isn't possible. They have to be disqualified," he said.

Mr. Banerjee said the Constitution clearly mandates that at least two-thirds of the political party, and not just the legislature party, must agree to a merger for it to be considered valid.

"We have left it to the judgment of the Speaker. Mr. Birla told us that he will call the 20 rebel MPs for a hearing and then come back to us. I hope the Lok Sabha Speaker works on a constitutional basis and does not smother the Constitution," he said.

Mr. Banerjee accused the 20 MPs of "disrespecting" the Constitution and betraying the mandate of the people. "They claim they have a problem with the Trinamool Congress, so then why not vacate the seats? If you have political integrity, let there be an election; they can contest on the BJP ticket or NCPI ticket and let the public decide," he said.

He alleged that external pressure and inducement were behind the decision of the 20 MPs. "Someone is worried about ED, someone about CBI, someone is

getting money, some are giving in to intimidation. I have concrete proof about this. If any of them feel offended by my remarks, they should file a case against me. I will prove it in a court of law," he said.

He said that in the past month and a half, he had been summoned five times. "Thrice I have gone to CID, twice my house has been raided," he said.

On the contrary, the security cover for the 20 MPs has been enhanced by a government "that runs bulldozers on people", he added.

Sena (UBT) MP says no other option; points to lack of funds for development

**Vinaya Deshpande Pandit**  
MUMBAI

Omraje Nimbalkar, the Shiv Sena (UBT) MP speculated to be among a group of six breakaway MPs planning to form a separate bloc, broke his silence on Friday.

Speaking to *The Hindu* from Pune, the Lok Sabha member from Dharashiv said he felt torn and did not think he had been left with any other alternative. On whether he had already formed a separate group, he said he would speak about it only on Sunday or Monday.

On whether he was slated to meet Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister and Shiv Sena chief Eknath Shinde, he replied in the negative. He said he would decide on his future course of action only after speaking with the people in his constituency.

"Let the verdict in my father's murder come... I am seeking justice for my father... The CBI has done a good job. The trial went well. It is a very emotional point for us. My father was murdered. And I seek justice," he told *The Hindu*. Mr. Nimbalkar's father,



Omprakash Nimbalkar

Congress leader Pawanraje Nimbalkar, was shot dead in 2006 by alleged contract killers. A special CBI court in Mumbai will pronounce its judgment in the murder case on Saturday.

**Key case**

The case, which has seen a trial lasting 15 years, alleges that former Nationalist Congress Party MP Padamsinh Patil orchestrated the murder of Pawanraje Nimbalkar using contract killers. Mr. Patil is the elder brother of Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar.

When Mr. Nimbalkar was asked if his decision to switch over depended on the court verdict, he said: "No. I am waiting for the verdict, but my decision will not depend on that." Hinting that he was be-

ing forced to move out of the Shiv Sena (UBT), he said it had become difficult to function effectively due to the lack of funds.

"We [our party] could not win any Nagar Panchayat or Nagar Samiti elections. Don't even ask about Zilla Parishad... In Dharashiv, my candidate was relegated to the third position. After being available for the people in the constituency, after working for them for 24 hours, if this is what people want, then they want only those who are in power," he claimed.

Responding to a question on the alleged backlash and the increase in security, Mr. Nimbalkar said he was a "people's person". "There is no fear of backlash. I will go to my own people. I feel bad that I don't get funds for the development of my own people. I am opposed when I want to get my people's work done. Are you stopping me because I am in Opposition? All these things are impacting me in the elections. My people expect me to deliver, and I am unable to work for them. What alternative am I left with?" he asked.

Parliamentary panel seeks clarity from govt. on future engagement with Pakistan

**Sobhana K. Nair**  
NEW DELHI

Days after RSS leaders advocated keeping the window open for "people-to-people" ties with Pakistan, members of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs on Friday questioned Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri and other officials on whether the government is considering such a step.

Ministry officials said Track-II diplomacy by non-governmental groups has continued with Pakistan, though they did not express confidence in it having any significant impact on changing Pakistan's stance.

The meeting was convened to brief the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs, headed by senior Congress leader Shashi Tharoor, before the panel's study tour to Jammu, Srinagar, and Leh from June 22 to 25.

According to sources, several questions were raised on future engagement with Pakistan, including whether Prime Minister Narendra Modi



Congress MP Shashi Tharoor interacts with Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri in New Delhi. PTI

would attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit slated to be held in Pakistan next year. The Ministry did not give a clear reply, saying it is too early to take a call.

Specifically, after government-to-government talks between the two countries made little headway, questions were raised on whether the Modi government is open to encouraging people-to-people ties. According to sources, the External Affairs Ministry said the government desires "normal neighbourly relations" but emphasised that this has to "happen in an atmosphere free of violence and terro-

rist activity".

The Ministry also pointed out that 4,600 Indian pilgrims have visited Pakistan this year. The diplomatic mission, along with weekly telephone calls between Directors General of Military Operations (DGMOs) across the Line of Control, has continued, officials said. The ceasefire has also largely held, a Ministry official added.

On China, External Affairs Ministry officials, according to sources, stressed that people-to-people ties are strengthening. More visas are expected to be issued this year for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra.

Attempt to tarnish image: CPI(ML) on 'cross-voting'

**The Hindu Bureau**  
PATNA

Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya on Friday wrote to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge protesting against the allegations of cross-voting levelled against the party following the Rajya Sabha elections in Jharkhand.

After the results were declared, Jharkhand Congress in-charge K. Raju had blamed the allies' partner, Rashtriya Janata Dal, and CPI(ML)L for the Congress candidate's defeat.

In his letter, Mr. Bhattacharya said that such unverified allegations against allies undermine mutual trust among parties of the INDIA bloc.

"I write to you to express our protest against the malicious propaganda against our MLAs and the attempted tarnishing of our party's image. In election after election, our MLAs in Bihar and Jharkhand have voted for Opposition candidates in the Rajya Sabha," he said, adding that his party was a committed constituent of the INDIA bloc.

Uddhav offers to step down as party chief while Shinde hints at more defections

**Vinaya Deshpande Pandit**  
MUMBAI

In an emotional appeal to his party leaders and cadres on the 60<sup>th</sup> foundation day of the united Shiv Sena on Friday, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray offered to step down as the party's president if they believed in the allegations levelled against him by the defected parliamentarians.

He also called for starting 'Operation Lotus' in response to 'Operation Tiger' allegedly carried out by the Shiv Sena to lure six of its nine Lok Sabha MPs into its fold. Mr. Thackeray also refuted allegations that his party was likely to merge with the Congress.

Targeting the BJP for "dirty politics", he said that Gen Z, which was being termed as "cockroaches", would bring about a change in the country. He hit out at the party for using 2.5 lakh paramilitary forces in West Bengal "to defeat a woman", challenging the government to use the special force in Manipur or in Pakistan Occupied Kashmir instead.



Uddhav Thackeray

"The BJP is moving from 'One Nation, One Election', to 'One Nation, No Election'," he said. "We will have to do Operation Lotus. The way politics of this country is being conducted, people's faith in democracy is eroding. This is a threat to democracy. The way we are going currently, we are moving towards anarchy," he said.

Taking a dig at the MPs who have allegedly defected, he said that his party did not merge with the BJP despite being with them for 30 years. "And those who are leaving say that they feared we will merge with the Congress," he said while speaking to party cadre at Mumbai's Shanmukhanand Hall. He was

accompanied by his son Aaditya Thackeray, wife Rashmi Thackeray, party MPs, and MLAs.

Meanwhile, during the foundation day event at NESCO Ground in Goregaon, Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister and Shiv Sena leader Eknath Shinde hinted at more defections. Without referring to 'Operation Tiger', he said that the public "has only seen a trailer, and that the movie was yet to be screened". "Balasaheb Thackeray's true heirs are my Shiv Sainiks. Succession is not determined by blood relations but by ideology. Shiv Sena is not a piece of land; it is the ideology of millions of people," he said.

The background of these events on Friday was the turbulence caused due to the speculations that six MPs from Shiv Sena UBT are likely to defect and join Eknath Shinde. This will bring down the party's strength in Parliament from nine MPs to three MPs. Shiv Sena UBT is am important ally in the INDIA Bloc. This is the second split in the last four years to have rocked the party.

A.P. CM Naidu to release ₹3,125-cr. aid to farmers

**The Hindu Bureau**  
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh government will release the first instalment of financial assistance under the Anna-data Sukhibhava-PM Kisan scheme for the 2026-27 financial year on Saturday, benefiting nearly 46.86 lakh farmer families.

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu will formally launch the disbursement from Linganguntla village in Palnadu district. Under the programme, a total of ₹3,125.47 crore will be credited directly into the bank accounts of 46,85,838 eligible farmer families. Beneficiaries include 45,69,817 land-owning farmers and 1,16,021 farmers cultivating land under the Recognition of Forest Rights (RoFR) Act.

The Annadata Sukhibhava programme, one of the key welfare initiatives under the government's Super Six commitments, provides annual assistance of ₹20,000 to every eligible farmer family.

Officials say the scheme is aimed at reducing the investment burden on farmers and making agriculture more remunerative.

UDF government banks on 'dream projects' to transform Kerala

**Tiki Rajwi**  
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government's 'dream projects' for transforming Kerala into a cohesive port city and an aviation hub, a Land Reforms 2.0 initiative for harnessing land for development, and a Kerala Knowledge Valley designed to make the State a higher education destination feature high on the revised Budget for the 2026-27 fiscal presented by Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan in the Assembly on Friday.

Among other things, Mr. Satheesan, who handles

the Finance portfolio, enhanced the support price of rubber from ₹200 to ₹250 and the kerosene subsidy for fishers to ₹75.

A glut of announcements marked his one-hour-38-minute presentation of the Budget which promised "governance with empathy."

Other major announcements included a 'Southern Kerala Economic Corridor' linking Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam, and Alappuzha districts, a plan for a tribal university and indigenous knowledge zone in Wayanad and a 'Global Job Watch Tower' for monitor-

ing future employment landscapes.

The Budget largely steered clear of tough fiscal restructuring, whereas the recent White Paper had observed that the State's fiscal health was under "serious and growing strain."

Major allocations in the Budget include ₹600 crore for financing the Indira Guarantee free-travel scheme for women and transgender persons on ordinary buses of the Kerala State Road Transport Corporation, ₹400 crore for Mission Samudra projects which include the 'Kerala as a port city' proposal, ₹100 crore for a Rare Earth



Kerala CM V.D. Satheesan presents the revised budget in the Kerala Legislative Assembly, in Thiruvananthapuram, on Friday. PTI

and Critical Minerals Corridor, ₹200 crore for the preliminary activities of the aviation hub proposal, ₹100 crore for the Kerala

Knowledge Valley, and ₹50 crore for the Wayanad tribal university project.

Further, the Budget earmarks ₹100 crore for a

'Kerala Health and Life Sciences city' which is envisioned as an integrated healthcare ecosystem meant to deliver high-standard healthcare services and promote medical education and research.

Elderly care is another thrust area in the Budget. A comprehensive 'silver economy policy' will be framed for Kerala in line with the government constituting a dedicated department for the welfare of the aged, Mr. Satheesan said.

Mr. Satheesan announced plans to constitute an expert committee to initiate a comprehensive

structural reform and overhaul of the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB), in line with a recommendation in the White Paper on the State's fiscal health.

**Silent on pensions**

The Budget was silent on welfare pensions or on the question of revising the retirement age of government employees, but it says that the NPS pension scheme will be revamped after reviewing the Assured Pension Scheme announced by the previous LDF government.

The Budget also revived the proposals for Light Me-

tro projects in the cities of Thiruvananthapuram and Kozhikode. The road tax on electric vehicles priced up to ₹10 lakh has been reduced from 5% to 3%.

The other major announcements include a 'Kerala MSME Growth Scheme' and a family health insurance coverage up to ₹25 lakh named after former Chief Minister Oommen Chandy.

The Budget envisages revenue receipts of ₹1,69,646.37 crore and revenue expenditure of ₹2,05,001.67 crore, both estimates lower than in the 2026-27 pre-poll Budget presented by the LDF in January this year.





## Defection as merger

The Tenth Schedule is hollowed out by unprincipled politics

There is something deeply troubling about the wave of defections sweeping India’s elected representatives, Members of Parliament chief among them. In the latest episode, six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs are seeking to join the Eknath Shinde faction of the Sena, which emerged after an earlier split in the parent party. This group constitutes exactly two-thirds of the party’s Lok Sabha strength, giving them the escape route that their crossover will constitute a merger under the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, or the anti-defection law. Under the Tenth Schedule, a member can be disqualified if they voluntarily resign from their party or defy a party whip during a division of votes in the House. In 2003, the law was strengthened by an amendment that removed the earlier “split” provision – which had allowed one-third of a party’s members to defect without penalty – and retained only the “merger” exception, under which disqualification does not apply if two-thirds of a party’s legislators agree to merge with another party. Engineered splits are now dressed up as mergers, letting groups defect without inviting disqualification. The legal validity of such claims is itself contested, as the Supreme Court of India has, in a past judgment, made clear that a merger cannot be of the legislature party alone, and must involve the parent party as well.

With the Court holding back judgments on several constitutional questions related to this, presiding officers keep waving through such stretched claims – and the practice keeps gathering pace. The Sena splintering follows close on the heels of the TMC rebellion. A rebel group claiming the support of 20 of the TMC’s 28 Lok Sabha MPs – led by four-time MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar – has aligned itself with the BJP-led NDA, seeking a merger with another party. In April, AAP MPs in the Rajya Sabha had joined the BJP, reducing AAP’s Rajya Sabha strength from 10 to three. Now, three TMC members of the Rajya Sabha, Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Sushmita Dev and Prakash Chik Baraik, have resigned. For all practical purposes, the Tenth Schedule has become redundant and irrelevant, as the Court keeps key decisions pending. The surge in these crossovers, which has the cumulative effect of increasing the strength of the ruling NDA in the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha, raises questions beyond technicalities. At present, the NDA does not have the two-thirds majority in Parliament needed to pass constitutional amendments. The threshold of two-thirds for constitutional amendments is kept high to ensure a wide political consensus. By-passing that intent through defections – whatever name they go by – is an affront to representative democracy and the spirit of the Constitution.

## Right of way

India needs to build more footpaths to help pedestrians walk freely

As part of the Supreme Court’s expansion of Article 21 since the 1970s, it has declared the right to walk on demarcated footpaths a fundamental right. The Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Atul S. Chandurkar reaffirmed the right in a case seeking higher compensation for a five-year-old boy’s death after being struck and killed by a tanker lorry in Karnataka. As motorised transport has become more widespread, the Bench noted with regret that walking has become an inconvenience, with motorists often treating pedestrians as a ‘nuisance’ to be tolerated or cleared. In the absence of a national law governing pedestrian rights, responsibility for pedestrian safety is split across municipal laws, town-planning statutes, and street design guidelines. As such, pedestrians are considered to be safe if they face no immediate physical harm. Most cities also lack continuous unobstructed footpaths; where footpaths do exist, they are often encroached on by parking, vendors, utilities, and construction debris, and competing pressures such as road widening work.

While a right to walk is desirable, the ideas that pavements belong to pedestrians and that they have right of way should be cultural in order to endure. Rights-based legislation in India that has sought to change public culture has had mixed success. The Street Vendors Act 2014 sought to protect vendors from harassment as under Article 19(1)(g). But in most cities, municipalities still conduct “eviction drives” while implementation has lagged because the Act requires surveys, town vending committees, and the demarcation of vending zones – processes that many urban local bodies have delayed or simply abandoned. Weak implementation has allowed informal rent-seeking by officials to persist in some cases. The new judgment is also likely to set up disputes with the 2014 Act. Second, the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act 2003 curtailed public smoking over 20 years, but not by “restitutionary remedies”, as the Court has suggested for walking, but with consistent social messaging and small, immediate fines. Finally, despite strict laws and ‘Swachh Bharat’ mandates, the culture of littering remains because the law focuses on citizens’ duty to segregate whereas the state has often overlooked its duty to collect segregated waste. Similarly, if the state does not build footpaths, the citizen’s right will be meaningless. The Court’s constitutional nudge may thus lead to no real change if it remains a legal tool for compensation after a tragedy. A state using it to ‘cleanse’ streets of informal commercial activity could also gentrify these public spaces and criminalise the survival of the urban poor. The nudge’s principal path to success will be by moving the state’s funds towards pedestrian infrastructure.

India is leaving tens of gigawatts (GW) of cheap solar and wind power stranded – not because the projects are not ready, but because the grid is not. Upgrading the existing grid with advanced technologies and adding storage at key nodes can unlock 1,000 GW of new clean energy, without acquiring any additional land for transmission.

India is on the verge of a major shift in its electricity system. Solar and wind are now the country’s cheapest power sources, and deployment is accelerating, with over 45 GW added in 2025, roughly matching the United States. Paired with some of the world’s lowest battery costs, India can now deliver firm clean power at about ₹3.5 per kWh.

Yet, just as technology and prices have aligned, transmission has become the defining constraint. More than 50 GW of clean capacity is already stranded because projects can come online in 12 to 18 months, but transmission takes three to five years to build, slowed by land acquisition, multi-agency approvals, and restrictions on new corridors. Without faster and smarter grid expansion, the benefits of low-cost clean energy will remain out of reach.

India has about 250 GW of renewables today, 100 GW under construction, and will need about 2,000 GW by 2050 to meet rising demand and electrify industry and transport. This implies one of the largest transmission build-outs anywhere in the world. The question is no longer whether India must build more lines – it must – but whether new lines alone will suffice. They will not. India needs both major new transmission and far better use of the network it already has.

### Creating clean-energy superhighways

India can unlock the equivalent of nearly 1,000 GW of renewable energy far faster than building new lines by tapping the vast potential of its existing grid. Much of this potential is hidden in plain sight. Four opportunities stand out.

Storage unlocks more from the same wires. First, most renewable plants today use their transmission connections only about 25% of the time. For example, solar energy fills the transmission line during the day, but the same connection sits idle during evening peaks and at night. It is a bit like a highway used only during rush hour – busy for a few hours, empty the rest of the day. Adding batteries at the same locations allows power to be stored and delivered during evening peaks and at night, raising utilisation two to three times without new corridors or land. This directly enables the equivalent of 400 GW of additional clean energy.

Coal corridors can also carry clean power. Second, power lines connected to coal-based



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The country’s clean-energy future depends on faster, smarter grid expansion and optimisation

power plants offer another major opportunity. Many high-cost or old coal plants, totalling about 100 GW, operate at low output for long periods despite having valuable transmission connections. Locating solar and wind near these stations allows clean power to use this underused capacity whenever coal units are not fully loaded. In many hours it is cheaper to transmit renewable power than to run the coal plant, giving developers access to scarce grid connection and providing coal plant owners new revenue from underutilised assets. This approach can enable the equivalent of 100 GW of additional clean energy.

Using existing substations. A third opportunity sits at existing transmission substations. Many of these locations can take on new grid connections, letting more renewable projects plug straight into the system. Coupling these nodes with batteries can further support peak-demand supply and help manage power flows. Nationally, this could support around 100 GW of additional clean energy.

Modern wires can carry double the power. And fourth, much of India’s grid still uses older wires or conductors that sag under heat and restrict flow. Replacing them with high-temperature, low-sag conductors – manufactured domestically – can nearly double transfer capacity on the same towers and rights-of-way. It is like upgrading the engines on a train so it can haul twice as many goods on the same track – no new land, just better technology. This added headroom allows reconductoring to double the clean energy enabled by storage and shared transmission connections – raising the total potential to over 1,000 GW within the current transmission footprint and effectively transforming today’s corridors into clean-energy superhighways.

### A rapid path

Crucially, these solutions can be deployed within months, not years. They require no new land for transmission, minimal permitting, and far fewer approvals than building new corridors. They can relieve bottlenecks immediately, connect stranded clean power, and let new renewable projects advance while new lines catch up. They also improve grid utilisation and lower the average cost of using the grid.

New renewable energy projects will still require significant land, but locating them near coal plants, renewable energy hubs, or substations – where some land and grid access already exist – offers a practical, lower-conflict pathway as suitable land becomes increasingly difficult to secure.

India must build new transmission, but it must

build it smart. A new line built with advanced conductors and designed to work with storage can carry four to five times more clean power for only a modest additional cost. And with India planning a 40% expansion of its grid over the next decade, costing well over \$100 billion and ranking among the world’s largest buildouts, every kilometre must be future-proofed from the start.

India will need both approaches. Upgrading and optimising the existing grid offers the fastest relief to today’s bottlenecks, while smarter, higher-capacity new transmission infrastructure will be essential to support the massive renewable energy expansion required in the coming decades.

### The policy shifts that will determine success

India already enjoys structural advantages: a unified national grid and a track record of adding transmission capacity faster than many developed countries. In the U.S. and parts of Europe, the inability to connect low-cost renewable energy to the grid has become the most severe bottleneck in the energy transition. As India accelerates renewable deployment, it can avoid this trap through forward-looking policy.

Three shifts matter most. First, India’s national electricity regulator has already created enabling rules that require solar plants to make better use of their grid access by pairing with storage. This approach now needs to be implemented and expanded at the State level, with regulators and utilities actively incorporating it into planning and procurement decisions.

Second, regulation and procurement norms should reward the use of advanced transmission technologies that cost slightly more upfront but deliver greater system-wide benefits over their lifetime by expanding capacity without the need for new corridors.

Third, the coordinated development of large renewable energy zones and optimised transmission corridors is essential to overcome site-selection, planning, and timing challenges, and to enable the efficient movement of vast volumes of low-cost clean energy.

These measures will help India sustain its lead in low-cost clean power at a time when industries such as steel, aluminium, cement, data centres and chemicals are increasingly demanding reliable 24x7 electricity at predictable prices. The path ahead is clear: build all the transmission India can – and get far more out of every line. The grid is no longer background infrastructure. It is India’s next engine of growth, and a cornerstone of a low-cost, high-productivity future.

# Moving from drone purchases to drone partnerships

The Indian government’s planned \$2 billion drone procurement from domestic manufacturers reinforces its commitment to indigenous manufacturing and will boost the country’s growing drone industry. It also signals a shift from buying large, sophisticated platforms such as fighter aircraft to smaller, cheaper and more attributable systems. This shift also means procurement practices will have to address the challenges that come with the territory.

Long-term capital procurement that deals with systems such as tanks and fighter jets, is likely to struggle to keep pace with the rapid demand for upgrades and modifications. The willingness to spend money on these platforms is a good sign, but the question now is whether procurement systems will spend it well.

### The economics of drones

Although public conversations about military drones typically focus on large uncrewed combat aerial vehicles (UCAVs) such as the MQ-9B Reaper and the Bayraktar TB-2, recent conflicts have exemplified the utility of smaller, cheaper drones.

These typically fall within the ‘micro’ and ‘nano’ drone categories, and are built to be cost-effective. Both Iran’s use of drones against the United States and Israel, and the use of drones in the Russia-Ukraine war, have followed this principle. Intercepting drones that are being used to strike high-priced hardware, is typically far more expensive than the drones themselves. The trend across recent wars has been to produce vast numbers of cheap drones, and deploy them in large numbers. Creative uses and modifications of drones that were originally manufactured for commercial use, have also served as an inexpensive means to achieve military objectives.

Ukraine’s use of first-person-view (FPV) drones that have been retrofitted with warheads has made many headlines. Innovation in the defence



Adya Madhavan

Researcher at the Takshashila Institution

India’s drone ambitions require smarter contracts and continuous innovation

drone sector is therefore closely linked to innovation in civilian drone technology, creating a need for more iterative and collaborative research and development (R&D) processes. The case of the Chinese drone industry demonstrates the benefits of closer collaboration among industry, academia and the military.

### The challenge of drone relevance

The other unique aspect of procuring tactical drones, is that the challenge lies not in acquiring them, but in ensuring that they stay relevant. A state-of-the-art fighter jet or tank bought in 2015 is still relatively new today, and is reasonably competitive. Tactical drones bought today can be obsolete in as little as two to three years, as enemy capabilities and threat environments continue to evolve. Enemy electronic warfare (EW) units can adapt their jammers to the signal of a new drone in as little as six to eight weeks.

When Ukrainian engineers faced this issue, the solution was not to procure new systems with different communication links, but to replace radio links with fibre-optic cables. Processes need to be quick, and allow for rapid modifications and upgrades without the constraint of red tape and bureaucratic timelines.

Indian procurement frameworks have made some good provisions in this direction, but there is still scope for change. For instance, the draft Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) allows the armed forces to procure commercial-off-the-shelf (COTS) systems, enabling them to purchase commercial drones wherever they can be utilised. The DAP also has provisions to streamline upgrades. The Defence Procurement Manual (DPM) allows financial buffers for unforeseen repairs and upgrade costs. These are sensible moves.

The key shortcoming of current procurement frameworks is that buyer-seller relationships

remain fundamentally transactional. The underlying assumption is that once the government identifies a requirement, it can issue a tender and procure a product that meets it.

However, in a domain where technology evolves rapidly, products require continuous iteration and improvement.

### Partnerships, not transactions

A more suitable model for tactical drone procurement may resemble a managed service contract rather than like purchasing hardware.

Much like large organisations that procure computers with maintenance, software updates and replacement support, the armed forces could enter longer-term agreements with drone manufacturers. Such contracts would provide industry with demand predictability while ensuring assured supply, upgrade pathways and surge production capacity during conflicts. They would also create a framework for continuous improvements, including performance enhancements and adaptations to evolving electronic warfare threats. Most importantly, they would foster closer collaboration between the armed forces and industry in a domain where technology changes rapidly and future requirements are constantly evolving.

While Indian policy frameworks continue to take steps in the right direction, perhaps structural changes within these frameworks could create an environment better suited to keeping pace with the evolution of tactical drones. India’s domestic drone industry has the technical foundation to support a more sophisticated procurement relationship. The \$2 billion commitment is the clearest signal yet that the political will exists. Translating that into the right contractual architecture, one that prioritises sustained capability over one-off delivery, is the logical next step.

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Access to messaging app

Banning or blocking applications is not the way forward. Strengthening cybersecurity, plugging loopholes and improving preparedness should be the priority. Is the government’s fear that Telegram has evolved into a “new dark web” based on reality or on far-fetched assumptions? Telegram has existed for more than a decade and has not faced similar action in most other countries. Putting the platform itself on trial cannot be a

sufficient justification for a ban. Would the government halt all financial transactions simply because they can be misused by criminals?

Balasubramaniam Pavani,  
Secunderabad

### A truce with Iran

U.S. President Donald Trump’s words — that he would “go back to shooting and dropping bombs” if he dislikes how things unfold — reveal how personal the agreement with Iran really is. Quiet, sustained

diplomacy, not theatrical signings, will determine whether this truce outlasts the season.

A. Myilsami,  
Coimbatore

### New Chairman

My association with *The Hindu* dates back to 1960. The newspaper helped shape my career in the Railways and strengthened my competitiveness in public life. I have maintained an unbroken bond with this illustrious publication throughout my

life, which has now entered its eighth decade. I have followed the developments that have contributed to its growth. The unanimous appointment of Mr. N. Murali, a veteran with vast experience and deep expertise in the publishing industry, as the new Chairman of the Board of Directors of The Hindu Group Publishing Private Limited, is in keeping with *The Hindu*’s rich tradition and legacy.

N. Sadasivan Pillai,  
Kollam, Kerala

As a reader for the past six decades, I plead for improving the quality of news reporting, and to monitor accuracy, fairness and have balance without any political support. I am sure that the ‘ABCD’ of newspapers — Accuracy, Balance, Credibility, Democracy — in its presentation will be continued under the new Chairman’s guidance.

A.J. Rangarajan,  
Chennai

Art and culture are

inseparable aspects of human life. Since its inception more than a century ago, *The Hindu* has, in keeping with its founding principles, served as a custodian of India’s art and culture. Readers look forward to positive changes in its policies and a renewed focus on art and cultural issues.

V.P. Dhananjayan,  
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

# GROUND ZERO



Census enumerators at Shashi Garden in the Mayur Vihar area in New Delhi. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

## The pressures of counting India

Enumerators working on the Census are facing several challenges in the field, including heat, connectivity issues, and safety concerns. Though the exercise is being conducted through a digital system designed for real-time monitoring, field workers say conditions on the ground and supervisory instructions are affecting data collection. **Vijaita Singh** reports on the challenges

Every day for about a month, M. Soumina, a government-school teacher, began her mornings by knocking on the doors of apartments in a multi-storey residential complex in East Delhi's Mayur Vihar.

Although the school where she taught was closed for the summer break, Soumina had her task cut out for her after being appointed an enumerator for the ongoing Census. The exercise relies on about 33 lakh government teachers and other enumerators, who will spend nearly a year surveying an estimated 1.4 billion Indians on housing, amenities, and demographics.

For Soumina, the work meant spending hours going door to door in a brutal Delhi summer, with temperatures consistently hovering between 40°C and 42°C. She surveyed 150 flats spread across 17 apartment blocks and administered a 33-question survey to each household within 26 days.

"I was making those visits daily from May 19," said Soumina. "I had an app on my phone to record the data. Before asking the questions, the households also have to be mapped and geo-tagged on the app."

Other than her smartphone, a black bag, a QR-enabled identity card, and a white cap with the Census logo to protect her from the heat, Soumina's companion during these visits was her husband, who works in the production unit of a newspaper. She said she felt safer with him around.

Like Soumina, enumerators working on the Census report facing several challenges in the field, including heat, connectivity issues, and safety concerns. Though the exercise is being conducted through a digital system designed for real-time monitoring, field workers said conditions on the ground and supervisory instructions are affecting data collection. Many of them have also flagged these issues on social media.

### A massive exercise

The questions that enumerators asked are part of the Houselisting and Housing Operations (HLO), the first phase of the Population Census 2027. The questionnaire was notified by the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India on January 22.

The 2027 Census marks several firsts: it is India's first fully digital Census, the first to collect caste data, and the first to allow residents to self-enumerate. The exercise was originally scheduled for 2021, but was postponed because of the COVID-19 pandemic. As a result, India is conducting its population count six years later than the decennial schedule, with governments continuing to rely on 2011 Census data for policy planning and welfare programmes.

The HLO phase involves the collection of data on housing conditions, household composition, basic amenities, and assets to assess living standards. It captures information on the structure of dwellings; access to water, sanitation, and energy, ownership of consumer goods, and the number of people living in a household. It also collects residents' mobile numbers for official communication.

The HLO phase will lay the foundation for the second phase of the Census – Population Enumeration – scheduled for February 2027. In La-



When I filled untreated tap water as an option, the supervisor and the charge officers asked me to change the entry to tap water from treated source.

Census enumerator

dakh and the snow-bound regions of Uttarakhand, Jammu and Kashmir, and Himachal Pradesh, both phases have been set a deadline of September 30, 2026, due to weather constraints.

The second phase will enumerate caste and collect other detailed individual-level data, including religion. Each enumerator gets an honorarium of ₹25,000 for completing the task. So far, 23 States and Union Territories have completed the first phase.

### Meeting strangers

With several occupants being working professionals, Soumina said it was difficult to get them to answer questions during the day.

"Most residents leave for work around 8.30 in the morning. So I visited homes between 7 and 7.30 with my husband. While some were accommodative, others asked us to come again later or skip the exercise altogether," she said.

If a house was locked, she would go back again and again until she got the data, Soumina added. "Sometimes the visit extended into the evening, so I would again go with my husband."

Like her, many female enumerators, mostly government school teachers, said they asked their husbands or other male members in their families to accompany them during field visits.

Meenu Verma, a primary school teacher from Rae Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh, said that her husband and brother-in-law helped her during the exercise. "I was assigned 172 houses," she said. "My husband and I used to wake up at 4 in the morning and reach the assigned village by 7. From 7 to about 11, we would find people in their homes, but after noon, due to the heat, the entire village would be deserted."

She said they would then hesitate to knock on doors. "Many of them had no awareness about the Census, so we had to first explain it them. I want to request the government to appoint enumerators in pairs. Or a male colleague should accompany a female enumerator. Not everyone is polite. And in villages, houses are spread afar," Verma said.

On May 21, a First Information Report (FIR) was registered against a Delhi resident for allegedly harassing a female Census enumerator while she was on duty. On June 13, a Delhi court convicted the accused, Sandeep Panwar, 43, for the crime. Earlier, on April 25, a female Census

enumerator was allegedly denied entry into an apartment building in Bengaluru where an unidentified individual allegedly used abusive language against her, following which an FIR was registered against him.

Dinesh Kumar Dwivedi, a Hindi lecturer at a government school, who was Soumina's supervisor, said six enumerators were reporting to him. "Fetching data from slum clusters was easier than seeking information from multi-storey apartments," he said.

In Haryana and Delhi, Census enumerators, mostly government school teachers, complained that they faced hostility and were denied entry by residents of high-rise buildings and residents' welfare associations (RWAs). The district administration of Gurugram wrote letters to RWAs saying that according to Section 8(2) of the Census Act, 1948, every resident is "legally bound" to answer Census-related questions to the best of their knowledge or belief.

"The slum residents were hesitant initially," said Dwivedi, who collected data as an enumerator during the 2011 Census. "They thought this was an exercise to demolish the slums. When they understood its purpose, they were more than forthcoming. Some thought that participating in it would make them eligible for government schemes. Many others came to us with documents, asking for help in applying for welfare schemes."

Dwivedi recalled that in 2011, the process was tedious: all the data had to be noted down on paper, which could get lost or damaged. He said residents were reluctant to share information on assets as they feared tax raids.

### The digital divide

Beyond personal safety, the digital divide in India has also affected fieldwork. In metros and towns with better mobile connectivity, enumerators entered data directly on their phones. Elsewhere, they said they recorded details on paper or in notebooks and uploaded them on the app after going back home.

According to the Comprehensive Modular Survey: Telecom, conducted from January to March 2025 as a part of the 80th round of the National Sample Survey, 83.3 % of rural households and 91.6% of urban households had access to Internet. The total number of households surveyed was 34,950 (19,071 in rural areas and 15,879 in urban areas) and the total number of people was 1.42 lakh (82,573 in rural areas and 59,492 in urban areas). In the survey, a person was considered to have "used the internet" if they had accessed it at least once in the past three months.

"Connectivity is a huge issue, especially in rural areas. Once an enumerator has logged in, it is difficult to make changes, and if the network is poor, the data can get corrupted," said an enumerator from U.P.

Enumerators use their own phones to collect the data and have been asked not to delete the apps during the enumeration phase. However, they said the app crashes often.

On the Google Play Store, the Census 2027 Houselist App, which has more than 10 lakh downloads, has a rating of 2.9. It can only be downloaded by authorised users – enumerators, supervisors, and charge officers. Of the 4,570 reviews submitted, 2,054 users gave it a one-star rating, while 1,735 rated it five stars.

### Facing FIRs

On the outskirts of Delhi, in U.P.'s Noida, Sector-6, Indu Prakash Singh, charge officer, who oversees the work of enumerators and supervisors, set up a camp office at the Indira Gandhi Cultural Centre to monitor Census-related work. Officials with technical expertise were stationed in a large hall, with computer screens placed on desks arranged in a semicircle.

Singh's job was to ensure the smooth conduct of the exercise, which entailed surveying 2,309 house-listing blocks (HLBs), each comprising 150-180 households with a population of 800-1,000. The exercise ran from May 22 to June 20 in U.P.

Though Census activities are usually carried out by government employees, in U.P., private-

school teachers were also enrolled to tide over the shortage of government school teachers.

"The district administration in Noida issued directions to engage teachers from private schools for Census work," Singh said.

"But some of them moved the Allahabad High Court, which ruled in their favour, and 50% of the 1,000 teachers who were trained backed out at the last moment. We were forced to engage NGOs and other private people for the task," said a government official in Noida.

In Maharashtra, over 500 private unaided and minority schools moved the Bombay High Court in May against notices, appointment orders, and coercive steps such as FIRs issued against their teaching and non-teaching staff for failing to report for Census duties.

On May 22, the Court granted interim protection to the school associations and observed that Section 4A of the Census Act applies only to "local authorities" and prima facie the Census Act and the Census Rules, 1990 do not impose any statutory obligation on private unaided schools to provide their staff as enumerators or supervisors.

There have been several instances of enumerators facing FIRs for not taking up the assigned work. Though the total figures are difficult to assess, at least two FIRs were filed in Haryana against 10 enumerators, while a case each was filed in Noida and Greater Noida against more than 80 enumerators on June 3.

The National Crime Records Bureau reports for 2010 and 2011, when the first and second phases of the Census were last conducted, do not mention any cases registered under the Census Act.

Enumerators took to social media to flag issues such as heat and connectivity problems. They also reported witnessing stark income inequality, and described pressure from superiors to edit data in the name of correcting discrepancies.

### Editing data

Earlier, it often took months or even years to process Census forms. Mobile apps have now enabled real-time data monitoring through the Census Management and Monitoring System (CMMS) portal. Access to the data entered via the app is available not only to enumerators, but also to supervisors and charge officers. Enumerators said they were asked to change data, particularly for questions related to sanitation, electricity, and LPG connection.

A school teacher in Delhi said during training, for a question relating to "access to latrine", they were asked not to select the "no" option. This is used as a category for households without access to a latrine, and indicates open defecation. The "Yes" option is further broken down into "Exclusively for household use only (1)," "Shared with other households (2)," and "Public latrine (3)."

"During training, we were told to fill in the data observed by us," said an enumerator from Rajasthan. "On the field, many residents in my enumeration block said they defecate in the open. When I submitted the data, I was asked by my supervisor to revisit the homes and revise the data to show that the households had access to a latrine, even if a public toilet was anywhere in the vicinity."

Another enumerator from U.P. said they were also asked to edit data on the main source of drinking water. The options include tap water from treated source/untreated source, well, hand pump, tubewell/borehole, spring, river/canal, tank/pond/lake, packaged/bottled water and other sources. Under the Jal Jeevan Mission, one of the flagship schemes of the Bharatiya Janata Party government, nearly 81.97% households in India have tap water connection.

"When I filled untreated tap water as an option, the supervisor and the charge officers asked me to change the entry to tap water from treated source. What is the point of door-to-door enumeration then," asked the enumerator.

The question on the availability of a kitchen and LPG/PNG connection were also edited, the enumerator added. "Even if the house has an LPG connection in their name, they were using cow dung cakes or wooden logs to cook as they had not refilled the cylinders for several months. If we mentioned firewood or charcoal as the response, which is what we observed, we were asked to change the entry to show that the main fuel is LPG," said an enumerator from Rajasthan. According to the Press Information Bureau, national LPG coverage rose from 55.9% in April 2014 to 107.2% in April 2026. Consumers grew from 14.51 crore to 33.39 crore in the same period.

On June 2, the Director of Census Operations, Rajasthan, wrote to all district functionaries saying "during the analysis of field data collected so far, some discrepancies have been noticed". Charge officers were instructed to "verify the block-level data through the CMMS portal, in accordance with the actual field situation."

Around 11 a.m. on June 12, Manish Kumar, a government employee, went to a building in Noida's Sector-2. An open drain flowed on the side. Several doors were locked since many of the occupants, largely migrants, were away at work. In the courtyard of the three-storey building, a woman was washing bedsheets in a corner using two tubs of water. A man was taking a bath in a narrow veranda outside his one-room accommodation, which he shared with six other members of the family.

Kumar knocked on each door to ensure that every household was enumerated. The rooms that were open mostly had women and children inside. While some residents responded immediately, others were suspicious of Kumar. He noted down the details, stepped out of the building, and then logged the information into the Census app on his phone.

He said he would return in the evening and over the weekend to reach residents whose doors were locked. "A household must be labelled vacant or locked only after multiple visits," he said.

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KARNATAKA

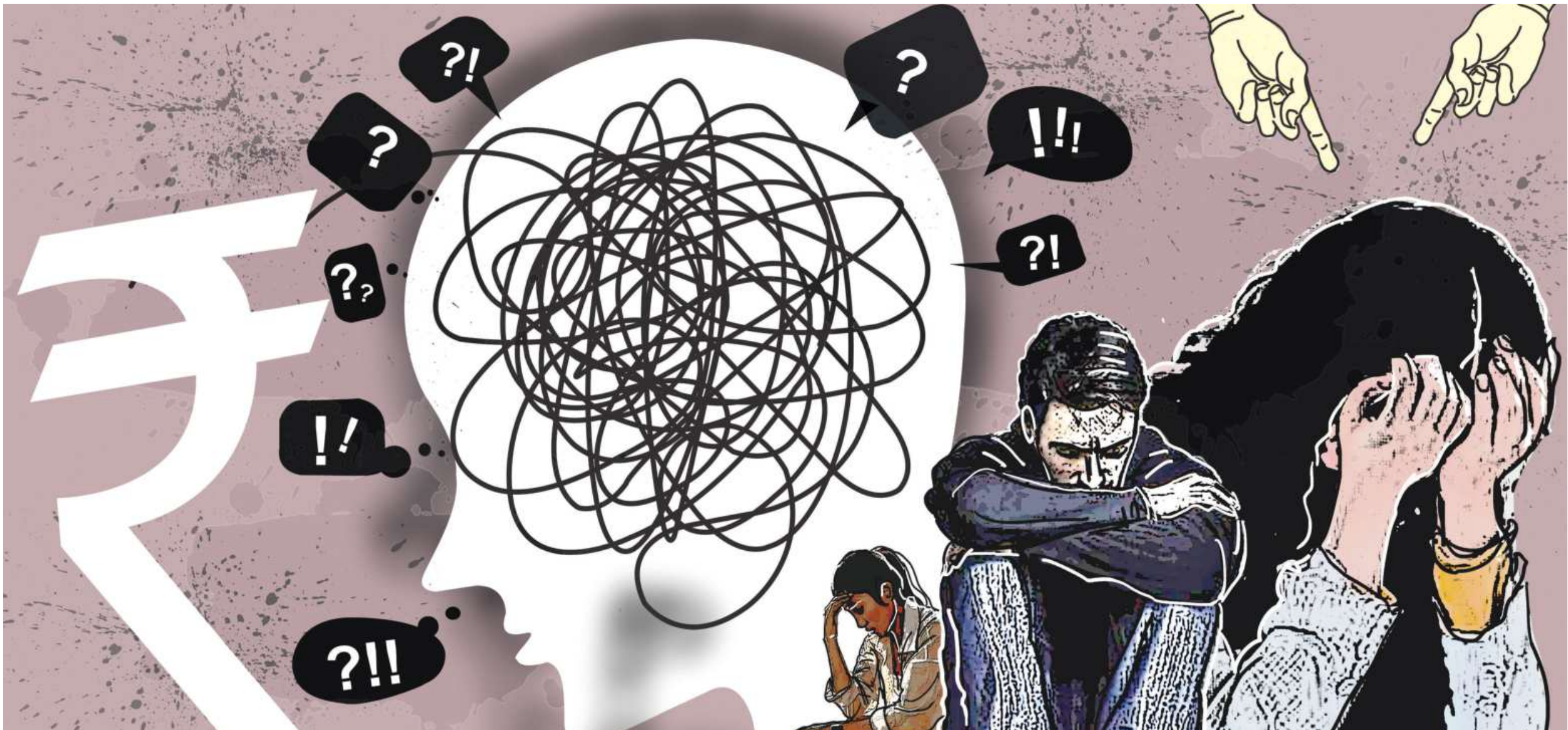


ILLUSTRATION: SEBASTIAN FRANCIS

# Fight against suicide moves from hospitals to communities

As Karnataka grapples with one of the country's highest suicide burdens, emerging evidence from NIMHANS-led initiatives suggests that prevention may lie not only in hospitals and psychiatric clinics, but also in schools, panchayats, primary health centres and everyday community networks. **Afshan Yasmeeen** recounts how the initiative, set to be scaled up across the State from July, works on the ground

A debt of ₹5,000 pushed a 28-year-old garment factory worker from rural Karnataka into one of the darkest moments of her life. Unable to repay money borrowed from her mother for a chit fund payment, she was reprimanded at home. Hurt, angry, and overwhelmed, she consumed a disinfectant lying in the house. Within minutes, she began vomiting and was rushed to hospital by her husband.

Today, she does not describe the incident as a planned attempt to end her life. Instead, she remembers it as the result of mounting financial stress, family tensions, and a feeling that nobody understood what she was going through. "I felt like nobody understood my tension," she recalls.

At the hospital, she was connected to counsellors associated with Project SURAKSHA, a community-based suicide prevention initiative led by NIMHANS with support from the Karnataka government and corporate social responsibility funds. Through counselling, follow-up calls and family support, she gradually regained confidence.

"They listened patiently and helped me understand that family and money problems can be solved

slowly and that I should not harm myself because of temporary stress," she says.

### Multiple reasons

Her experience is far from unique. A 33-year-old homemaker struggling with debt and family disputes. A 16-year-old boy grieving the loss of both parents who reacted after a friend insulted them. A 57-year-old government school teacher devastated by a family conflict that spilled into her workplace. Circumstances differ, but the emotions are similar – grief, loneliness, shame, financial stress, family conflict and a sense of having nowhere to turn.

These stories illustrate a reality long emphasised by mental health professionals: suicide and self-harm rarely stem from a single event. More often, they emerge from accumulated distress that remains unrecognised, unsupported or untreated until a crisis occurs. This understanding has shaped Karnataka's evolving approach to suicide prevention – one that increasingly seeks to move beyond hospitals and specialist psychiatric services into communities.

### Beyond clinical settings

"Community-based interventions are integral to suicide prevention. Engaging panchayat functionaries, schoolteachers, and other community influencers ensures that suicide is not hidden in the shadows," says NIMHANS Director Prabha S. Chandra. "When stigma decreases, people seek help and gatekeepers become more effective in preventing self-harm."

Dr. Chandra says evidence from Karnataka indicates that psychological interventions in emergency settings, followed by regular low-intensity follow-up contacts, can significantly reduce repeat attempts.

Anish V. Cherian, Principal Investigator of Project SURAKSHA and Lead of the NIMHANS Sui-

When stigma decreases, people seek help and gatekeepers become more effective in preventing self-harm.

**PRABHA S. CHANDRA,**  
NIMHANS  
Director

cide Prevention, Research, Implementation Training and Engagement Centre (N-SPRITE), says the programme has shown that suicide prevention can be woven into everyday community life.

"SURAKSHA involves collaborations between community members, government agencies, the private sector and non-government organisations. It incorporates several elements of India's National Suicide Prevention Strategy and is the first long-term community-based suicide prevention programme developed and implemented in India," he says.

According to Dr. Cherian, the programme offers a model that can be adapted across the country and incorporated into State-level suicide prevention plans.

### Karnataka's burden

The need for interventions becomes clear when viewed against Karnataka's suicide burden. According to the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), 1,70,746 people died by suicide in India in 2024. Karnataka remained among the five States reporting the highest numbers, accounting for 13,151 deaths, or 7.7% of the national total.

Bengaluru recorded the country's highest suicide rate among major metros. NCRB data showed over 2,313 suicides in 2022, 2,370 in 2023, and 2,430 in 2024, with the city's suicide rate remaining close to 20 per lakh population through the three-year period..

Yet, suicide deaths represent only the visible part of a much larger problem. Behind every death are many more individuals experiencing suicidal thoughts, emotional distress, self-harm, and suicide attempts.

Data generated through the Urban Self-Harm Study (USHAS), another NIMHANS-led initiative, provides a glimpse into this wider picture.

Between 2022 and May 2026, USHAS recorded 32,712 cases of self-harm and suicide attempts across 16 hospitals in Karnataka. Of these, 30,217 survived, representing 92.4% of all reported cases.

Among survivors, 24,361 people, or 80.6%, received psychosocial interventions, including brief counselling and structured telephone follow-up.

### Rate of repeat attempts

Only 381 individuals, or 1.5% of those who received interventions, went on to make another suicide attempt. International studies estimate repeat-attempt rates among survivors at 15% to 25%.

Among the 381 who re-attempted suicide, 78 died, representing just 0.32% of all those who had received psychosocial support.

Rajani Parthasarathy, Karnataka's Deputy Director (Mental Health), says the findings highlight the importance of continued support after a suicide attempt.

"By equipping public health facilities to record details of survivors and linking them to referral services, we ensure that no survivor falls

through the cracks. The brief interventions and long-term follow-up have resulted in significantly lower re-attempt rates."

### Understanding vulnerability

The USHAS data also sheds light on the factors driving suicidal behaviour. Nearly half of all reported cases had a previous history of suicide attempts, while more than 43% had engaged in self-harm earlier.

Young adults emerged as the most affected group. People aged 25 to 39 accounted for 44.4% of all reported cases, followed by those aged 18 to 24.

Interpersonal relationship issues emerged as the most common trigger, accounting for 46% of all cases. Financial and property-related concerns contributed to 9.3% of cases, while physical illness and mental health conditions accounted for 5.4% and 5.3%, respectively.

The findings reinforce a pattern often observed by mental health professionals: suicidal behaviour is frequently linked to everyday challenges, strained relationships, family conflict, debt, illness and emotional distress.

Recognising that suicide prevention cannot rely solely on hospitals, NIMHANS launched Project SURAKSHA in Channarayana taluk in 2023.

Developed in line with India's National Suicide Prevention Strategy and the World Health Organization's LIVE LIFE framework, the initiative sought to bring suicide prevention into communities.

Instead of depending exclusively on psychiatrists and psychologists, it focused on building local networks capable of identifying distress early and connecting vulnerable individuals with help.

Teachers, panchayat representatives, Accredited Social Health Activists, anganwadi workers, healthcare staff, self-help group members and police personnel were trained as gatekeepers.

The idea was straightforward: people experiencing emotional distress often interact with community members long before they reach a mental health professional. By strengthening those connections, the programme sought to create opportunities for earlier intervention. Three years later, the programme has begun to demonstrate what such an approach can achieve.

Initially implemented across 32 gram panchayats in Channarayana, SURAKSHA is now being extended to all five taluks of Bengaluru South. The Karnataka government has also approved its first phase in Ballari district, another region that reports high suicide numbers..

### Changing conversations

One of the most visible outcomes has been a shift in how communities talk about mental health. Leelavathi, Panchayat Development Officer of Nagavara Gram Panchayat in Channarayana taluk, says, "Earlier, people were afraid to openly speak about stress, depression or suicide. Many families suffered silently without knowing where to seek help."

Former Nagavara Gram Panchayat president

Harish Kumar C.S. says emotional distress often remains hidden because of social stigma. "People openly discuss physical illness but often hide mental health problems because of shame or fear. Awareness programmes helped people understand that seeking help is not a weakness," he says.

For many people, the first conversation about emotional distress occurs not in a psychiatrist's clinic but during a school interaction, community meeting, visit by a frontline worker or conversation with a trusted local leader.

### Strengthening primary healthcare

Another important aspect of SURAKSHA has been its effort to integrate suicide prevention into routine healthcare services.

Sahana Sitharam P., Medical Officer at Nagavara Primary Health Centre, says self-harm and emotional distress often went undetected in primary healthcare settings.

"Earlier, we focused more on emergencies and physical illness. Through training, staff became more confident in identifying vulnerable individuals and providing timely referrals," she says.

The programme introduced systems to record self-harm cases and ensure follow-up support. Such registries are important because previous suicide attempts remain among the strongest predictors of future suicide risk.

Alongside support for survivors, family-based postvention services have been delivered to 26,387 families affected by suicide attempts or deaths. These interventions focus on helping families cope with grief, reducing stigma and connecting them to available support systems.

### Building evidence for policy

Experts say Karnataka's experience is important because it generates evidence on what works in suicide prevention.

Lakshmi Vijayakumar, member of the WHO Network on Suicide Prevention and Research, points out that India accounts for more than a fifth of global suicide deaths. The National Suicide Prevention Strategy, announced in 2022, aims to reduce suicide deaths by 10% by 2030.

Pointing out that suicide patterns vary considerably across States, Dr. Vijayakumar argues that local strategies are essential. "Suicide rates vary widely across India. Each State needs a strategy that takes its culture and context into consideration. Suicide is a preventable public health crisis and the time to act is now."

The Karnataka experience has also highlighted the role of collaboration.

K.G. Umesh, Director-Human Resources, Himalaya Wellness Company, the CSR partner for the projects, says suicide prevention requires long-term collaboration. "Beyond funding programmes, CSR can help bring together institutions, expertise and communities to address complex public health challenges in a sustained manner," he says.

Beginning in July, the USHAS programme will expand to all districts of Karnataka, operating through five hospitals in Bengaluru and district hospitals across the State.

The programmes demonstrate that suicide prevention need not remain confined to specialist psychiatric services. It can be integrated into schools, primary healthcare centres, panchayats, community organisations and families.

The stories of the garment worker, homemaker, teenager and school teacher illustrate that point. None were facing extraordinary circumstances. Financial stress, grief, family conflict and social humiliation are experiences encountered by countless people.

What transformed those experiences into crises was a temporary absence of support and an inability to see alternatives in moments of overwhelming emotional distress.

The interventions that helped them recover did not always begin with specialised treatment. More often, they began with something simpler – a conversation, a follow-up call, a teacher who noticed, a health worker who listened, or a community member who reached out.

MAHARASHTRA



Taxi and auto drivers  
registering for a Marathi course  
at the Wadala RTO in Mumbai.  
EMMANUAL YOGINI

Linguistics  
over licences

Maharashtra's Transport Minister has made it mandatory for the State's taxi and auto drivers to learn Marathi by August 15 or lose their licences. **Chinmay R. Gaikwad** reports on how RTOs are doubling as classrooms for migrant drivers who are struggling to learn the basics of a new language in just four days of classroom learning. He finds that some drivers are hopeful, while some others feel humiliated

Inside Mumbai's Andheri Regional Transport Office (RTO), rows of plastic chairs that once held people waiting for their token numbers to take driving tests, now seat a different kind of crowd: auto drivers, with notebooks open, mouthing Marathi sentences for the first time in their working lives. The four-day Marathi course, introduced from June 1, has become an unlikely part at five of 25 RTOs, each in a different zone in Mumbai. Every day, 50 to 80 drivers turn up at each centre, racing to clear a language test before their permits are flagged.

The urgency stems from an announcement made in April by Pratap Baburao Sarnaik, Maharashtra's Minister of Transport and chairperson of the Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC). Sarnaik held a press conference to announce that taxi and auto drivers in Mumbai would need to know how to read, write, and speak Marathi, or risk losing their licences. Transport officials who issue licences without proper checks may also face action. The drive was to start from May 1.

His statement sparked a political storm within days, drawing backlash from the Shiv Sena's Sanjay Nirupam and Samajwadi Party leader Abu Azmi, who objected to the timeline. Sarnaik, who is also from the Shiv Sena, part of the ruling alliance, then pushed the deadline to August 15, giving drivers a longer window to learn to read, write, and speak in Marathi. Mumbai has 88,923 registered taxis and 4,22,990 autos, many of which are driven by people who have migrated to the State in search of work.

For some, the classroom is an unfamiliar and uncomfortable space, one that surfaces old anxieties about literacy, age, and what their children might think. Drivers, who have spent years memorising routes, fares, and the unwritten etiquette of Mumbai's roads, now find themselves holding a pencil again, sounding out words under the gaze of an instructor.

For some, the four days pass quickly, and without much fuss; for others, each session is a small, quiet reckoning with a part of their past they had hoped never to revisit.

Contrasting views

In Kurla, Moolachand Yadav, 53, who has been driving an auto in Mumbai since 1991, says he has no quarrel with the new requirement. "Itne saal se yahi sheher mein gaadi chala rahe hain, ab Marathi seekh lenge toh sawari bhi badhegi (I have been in this city for so many years now. Maybe learning Marathi will help me find more customers)," he says, confident of finishing the course. Yadav has watched the city change around him for over three decades: new flyovers, new fares, new passengers.



I am 42. My children go to school. If I also start going to school, my children will think I cannot read and write

RAKESH MANDAL  
Taxi driver,  
Mumbai

For him, Marathi is simply the next thing to adapt to, no different from learning a new route or a new app. Some drivers at his stand grumble about the classes cutting into their peak earning hours, but he chooses to see it differently. A few mornings spent learning the language, he reasons, could mean better conversations with Marathi-speaking passengers, and possibly more regular customers in the long run. For Yadav, the classes are less an imposition and more an opportunity, a way to earn the trust of more passengers, and with it, more money.

Not everyone shares his enthusiasm. In Govandi, in Mumbai's eastern suburbs, Rakesh Mandal bristles at the idea of sitting in a classroom. "Mera age 42 hai. Mere bachche school jaate hain. Agar main bhi school jaane lagunga, toh woh sochenge ki unka baap padha-likha nahi hai (I am 42. My children go to school. If I also start going to school, my children will think I cannot read and write)," he says, even though he admits quietly that he can't.

Mandal has driven a taxi in Govandi for 20 years, ferrying his own children to school before starting his shifts. The thought of his children seeing him study daily fills him with dread. The discomfort runs deeper than the test itself. For Mandal, going back to school risks exposing a gap he has spent decades concealing, and no certificate, he feels, is worth that cost.

Sarnaik feels that learning the language of the region where a person works is a responsibility. The Transport Department had received complaints, particularly from the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, and Nagpur, that many drivers were unable or unwilling to speak Marathi with passengers, he added, at the press conference.

RTOs turn schools

At the Andheri RTO, the person overseeing the programme is Deputy Regional Transport Officer Sudhir Jaybhaye. "On the first day (June 8) there were 52 students, the second day the numbers went up to 74. Now, we have 85-plus students in every batch," he says. Classes are between 12.30 p.m. and 1.30 p.m., which he says is between the hectic morning and evening office commute.

Jaybhaye explains that the office uses its routine paperwork as leverage to get drivers enrolled in the programme. When drivers come in to get new licences or renew old ones, or to register a vehicle, the RTO staff tells them to enrol in the free-of-cost Marathi course. "Drivers are told to finish the course first, after which their pending applications are taken up."

Anjali Deshpande, 73, one of the teachers at the Andheri centre, says attendance is recorded meticulously. She produces a sheet where each driver's licence number, vehicle registration number, and badge number is logged. Attending all four lectures and signing the attendance register is compulsory to receive a certificate, jointly issued by the Mumbai Marathi Sahitya Sangh and the Kokan Marathi Sahitya Parishad, well-known institutions for their work in the Marathi language, which are under the Department of Cultural Affairs, Maharashtra.

Deshpande is a retired clerk from the Centre's defence department who took voluntary retirement and turned to tutoring in Marathi and Hindi. She speaks warmly of her days teaching in the RTO classes. "More than 200 auto drivers now call me 'Marathi madam'. I now get a different, more pleasant kind of treatment from auto drivers when I step out to run errands," she says, laughing. Unlike in many parts of India, Mumbai's autos run by the meter, though fares can involve negotiation.

At the Wadala RTO, lectures held are between 1 p.m. and 2 p.m., during what is typically the RTO's lunch break. One of the course coordinators there explains the philosophy behind the teaching method: a combination of visuals and text. Most of

the instructors, she says, are retired professors and language teachers who have spent years in academics.

"The key difference between teaching children and adults, is that children ask far more questions and are starting from scratch, while adult learners tend to work through their difficulties on their own, with less hand-holding," she says, adding that the focus is on conversational Marathi. Students are taught 14 sentences. On the final day, students are tested on these, to qualify for the certificate. Officials say the test will assess whether a driver can read a signboard or document in Marathi, write a basic sentence, and hold a simple conversation in the language.

Commuters weigh in

The reactions to the drive are not confined to the drivers. Jyothi Ganta, a corporate professional who commutes nearly 9 kilometres daily from the Shimla House area to Fort, about 5 kilometres apart, in south Mumbai, offers a passenger's perspective. "It's not always necessary for drivers to speak Marathi. Sometimes commuters and drivers are both so busy on our phones that we just exchange OTPs, that's it," she says.

Ganta's mother tongue is Telugu, but she speaks Marathi fluently because she was born and raised in Mumbai. "When we change location geographically, only two things change: one is food, and the other is language. So, we should speak the language of the soil." Chetan Tokde, 28, an auto driver from Ambernath, in Thane district, takes a combative position. "Why should we change our language, our culture, our pride?" he says, adding that drivers unwilling to adjust "should go back to their hometowns". Maharashtra's Marathi-speaking drivers, he feels, are capable of running the city's transport on their own.

Vedant Jather, 34, a call-centre employee who commutes daily to Kanjurmarg station, strikes a more measured note. He says he has no problem with migrants, but he finds it telling that some drivers who had lived, worked, and earned in the city for more than 40 years had still not picked up the local language. "Is it possible that this would happen in Karnataka or Tamil Nadu?" he says, arguing that learning the local language is a responsibility drivers should have taken on themselves, rather than waiting for a government deadline to force the issue.

The political crossfire

Maharashtra Navnirman Sena's Mumbai vice-president Arvind Gawde is critical of the government's approach, framing the entire exercise as an attempt to woo migrant voters from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. "Why is this government running a 'learn Marathi' project for people coming from U.P. and Bihar?" he says, alleging that the ruling alliance wants to help migrants settle permanently in Mumbai and convert them into a vote bank.

He calls the exercise a "political theatre", questioning why taxpayer money is being spent on language instruction at all, pointing out that no other State runs comparable programmes. "Have you ever heard of Tamil Nadu's government spending money and manpower to teach its language to outsiders?" He also feels it is a poor use of the RTO's limited resources. The RTOs should be focussing on illegal drivers, road safety, and the broader problems plaguing public transport, than on what he dismissively calls "schooling these bhaiyyas".

The four-day Marathi course has, in a matter of weeks, become a small but telling window into the larger anxieties of language, identity, and belonging that continue to define life in Mumbai. As the August 15 deadline approaches, RTO offices across the city swell even as the debate over who truly belongs to the city, and on what terms, remains far from settled.

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Vidya Prabhu, a retired teacher, conducting a four-day speaking, reading, and writing Marathi course. EMMANUAL YOGINI

# ANDHRA PRADESH

# Hopes fade for many as pledged gold goes 'missing'

The alleged gold loan scam at Bank of Baroda in Jangaredygudem is proving to be more than just a banking issue. For farmers, women, and small traders, pledged gold often represents their final lifeline in times of hardship. Now, grappling with uncertainty, the borrowers await clarification. The disappearance of these ornaments has triggered not only financial distress but also deep emotional turmoil among them, explores **G.V.R. Subba Rao**

**P**ain, fear, and despair permeated the air outside the Bank of Baroda branch in Jangareddygudem as anxious customers, including women, gathered seeking information regarding their missing pledged gold ornaments. Armed with loan documents, passbooks, and pledge receipts, the crowd—grappling with uncertainty yet clinging to a sliver of hope—awaited clarification from bank officials regarding the status of the jewellery that had been entrusted to the bank in exchange for financial loans.

For many gathered, the gold meant more than just a financial asset; it was a family heirloom, a gift, or a blessing from parents or family—the only form of savings to sustain them in their time of need. While feeling dejected and wiping away tears, many recounted why they had to pledge the gold in exchange for a loan to raise money for cultivation, purchase seeds and fertilizers, meet irrigation expenses, or cope with medical emergencies and financial hardships.

Among those gathered was Dhana Lakshmi, the wife of Krishna Reddy, who was battling guilt and a sense of failure because she had pledged her daughter's gold chain, which had been entrusted to her during the Covid-19 pandemic to help with mounting medical expenses. She explained that her daughter had given her the chain after her marriage. Dhana Lakshmi pledged it with the belief that it would remain safe with the bank until the loan was repaid.

She claimed that the family had regularly paid interest and renewed the loan whenever necessary, hoping to redeem the ornament once their finances improved. To her shock, she found that the chain was reportedly missing, leaving her devastated. “How can I face my daughter? How can I return her gold chain?” she asked, struggling to hold back tears. “She trusted me with her jewelry during our difficult times. We pledged it only because we had no other option during the COVID crisis,” she added.

Her story resonated with many others, as several lamented that they too had pledged jewellery belonging to daughters, daughters-in-law, and relatives to overcome financial difficulties. The missing ornaments represented not only a financial loss but also the burden of explaining why the treasured family possessions could not be returned.

## 'Scam' unearthed

The alleged gold loan scam, which many believe would have remained hidden for years if not for Gavara Lakshmaiah, a small farmer cultivating paddy on his one-and-a-half-acre plot, came to light during his visit to the branch office on June 6 to settle his dues and reclaim his family's jewellery. His visit effectively opened a Pandora's box, exposing what customers now fear to be one of the most distressing breaches of trust they have experienced.

Lakshmaiah had pledged gold ornaments weighing eight kasu and availed himself of a loan of approximately ₹3 lakh. He stated that despite facing financial difficulties, he had diligently repaid the loan in instalments. What should have been a moment of relief soon turned into a nightmare when, during verification, he was reportedly informed that one of the pledged gold chains was missing. Shocked, he repeatedly sought clarification from the bank officials but received no satisfactory explanation.

"I had paid the instalments regularly and came prepared to clear the remaining dues and take back my gold. Instead, I was told that one of the chains was missing," he said. Even more disturbing was the possibility that the jewellery entrusted to the bank's custody had disappeared without explanation.

As word of Lakshmaiah's ordeal spread across



the town, panic set in. Borrowers rushed to verify the status of their own jewellery. The news spread rapidly across villages in the Jangareddygudem region as people contacted relatives and neighbours who had also taken out gold loans from the branch.

Within days, dozens of customers approached the bank seeking confirmation about their pledged ornaments. What initially appeared to be an isolated case soon evolved into a full-blown crisis. The panic was not only financial but deeply emotional, as each missing ornament carried stories of trust and tradition.

Like for R. Bhavani, who stood outside the bank with tearful eyes clutching her loan documents, it was her mangalsutra—a sacred symbol of marriage in Hindu tradition—that was now missing. She said that, like thousands of other rural women, she had entrusted the ornament to the bank, believing it would remain safe until she was able to redeem it. The jewellery, she said, carried memories of family bonds, years of shared struggles, and personal sacrifices. “For us, it is not just gold; it is our sentiment and our family’s honour,” she said.

As emotions ran high, the need for organised resistance grew stronger, and leading the crusade in the fight for justice is Satti Reddy, a farmer who has emerged as the key voice mobilising customers and coordinating protests. "People pledged their valuables because they trusted the bank. We believed our gold would remain safe until we repaid our loans and reclaimed it," he said.

Recalling his ordeal, Satti Reddy said that he had taken out a loan of approximately ₹3 lakh by pledging ornaments weighing about 12 kasulu, including traditional gold bangles. He claimed that the value of the pledged jewellery was far higher than the loan amount. “I needed only ₹3 lakh at that time, even though I pledged gold worth much more. Like most farmers, I never imagined there would be any risk because the ornaments were in the bank’s custody,” he said.

However, when he approached the bank to redeem his jewellery, he allegedly found that only gold corresponding to the loan amount was available while the remaining ornaments were missing. "When I went to settle the loan, only gold equivalent to the value of the loan amount was available. The remaining ornaments had disappeared," he alleged.

His experience became a rallying point for many affected customers who claimed that they, too, had pledged jewellery whose value exceeded the loans sanctioned. While banks generally lend only a portion of a gold ornament's market value, customers expect the entire quantity deposited with the bank to be returned after repayment.

As reports of missing ornaments multiplied, Satti Reddy began contacting other borrowers and encouraged them to verify their records. What started as isolated complaints gradually evolved into a collective movement demanding a comprehensive investigation, the recovery of missing gold, and action against those responsible. “The issue is not just about money,” he said, adding that it is about trust. “If people cannot trust a bank with their jewellery, where else can they go in times of need?” he questioned.

## Quest for truth

Moreover, the customers alleged that the bank was unaware of the scale of the problem until borrowers started assembling in large numbers to demand answers. While borrowers insist that the alleged scam came to light only after they discovered discrepancies and began protesting, senior Bank of Baroda officials present a different version. They maintain that internal vigilance mechanisms had already detected irregularities.

According to bank officials, a preventive vigilance audit had already been initiated well before customers began gathering at the branch. During the audit, discrepancies were reportedly identified and communicated to higher authorities. “The audit team noticed that something was amiss and reported the matter to headquarters,” a senior official said.

The bank maintained that information about the suspected irregularities spread among customers before verification could be completed, prompting widespread concern and protests.

The exact scale of the alleged loss, however, remains unclear. Bank officials have declined to disclose details of the ongoing audit or provide estimates regarding the quantity of gold that is allegedly missing.

Sources familiar with branch operations said that the Bank of Baroda branch manages a loan portfolio of around ₹100 crore, of which gold loans account for approximately ₹60 crore to ₹70 crore. A substantial portion comprises agricultural gold loans availed by farmers for cultivation, medical emergencies, and household expenses.

Despite the lack of official numbers and confirmation, farmer leaders and victims have attempted to estimate the extent of the damage. Andhra Pradesh Rythu Sangham district secretary K. Srinivas, along with Satti Reddy and Krishna Reddy, estimated that more than 2,700 customers have

pledged ornaments with the branch.

The jewellery carries memories of family bonds, years of shared struggles, and personal sacrifices. For us, it is not just gold; it is our sentiment and our family's honour

**R. BHAVANI**  
Pledgor

The absence of official figures has fueled speculation and heightened anxiety among borrowers. Until audit findings are made public and a complete inventory is verified, the true extent of the alleged fraud is likely to remain contested.

### System failure or simple oversight?

One question that continues to haunt customers is how such discrepancies could occur in a system designed with multiple layers of checks and balances. Gold loans are generally governed by a structured process involving valuation by authorised appraisers, verification by bank officials, documentation, secure storage, periodic audits, and supervisory oversight. Yet, preliminary findings and customer complaints suggest that several safeguards may have been bypassed or compromised.

Sources familiar with the inquiry said that the investigators found instances where mandatory branch manager signatures were absent from documents related to gold loan accounts. Such omissions have raised questions about whether established procedures were consistently followed. At the centre of the allegations is the role of the gold appraiser, who is accused of manipulating records while retaining the trust of custom-

ers. According to the victims, the appraiser recorded accurate details of pledged ornaments on the receipts issued to customers. However, when branch records were compared with customer receipts during verification, discrepancies allegedly emerged. In some cases, customers claimed that the quantity of gold recorded in internal records was lower than the quantity actually pledged. In others, the number of jewellery items shown in official records was allegedly fewer than what customers had deposited.

“The receipt given to the customer showed one thing, while the records reflected something else,” said one victim, adding “How could an ordinary farmer detect such manipulation when we trusted the documents issued by the bank?” The customers are now demanding a thorough investigation into whether the irregularities were the work of a single individual or reflected wider failures in oversight. Farmer leaders argue that the scale of the alleged fraud makes it difficult to believe that no warning signs emerged earlier. They have urged investigating agencies to examine the roles of all individuals involved in processing, verifying, and supervising gold loan accounts.

At present, no official findings have been released regarding the involvement of any bank employees beyond the allegations under examination. Bank authorities maintain that the verification process is still under way.

As protests intensified, the bank constituted five teams comprising five assayers and ten officials to verify documents and pledged ornaments. The teams submitted reports to higher authorities. Even though the victims alleged that the verification was not carried through to its logical conclusion, claiming that not all accounts and gold packets were examined, bank officials maintained that the verification exercise was completed and the report was submitted.

According to sources, compensation would be determined in accordance with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) guidelines, taking into account the value of gold as on June 1, 2026, when the issue surfaced. Customers may be offered either replacement gold or monetary compensation for any confirmed losses. But for many customers, however, the issue is not merely about compensation.

## 'False' security

Amid protests and demands for accountability, Bank of Baroda has reassured customers that their interests remain its foremost priority. In a statement, Bank of Baroda Deputy General Manager and Regional Head S.K. Kiran Reddy said, "The bank was committed to transparency and was conducting verification of all gold loan packets in the physical presence of customers. Qualified jewel appraisers and additional personnel have been deployed to ensure that the process is completed carefully and accurately."

Bank of Baroda firmly assures every affected customer that no grievance will go unaddressed. All concerns will be resolved in full compliance with regulatory guidelines and with the care they deserve, he stated.

But for families gathered outside the bank, the issue is much more than missing gold. It is about the erosion of trust in an institution they believed would safeguard their most precious possessions. Even as auditors continue to verify thousands of gold loan packets and investigators piece together what may have transpired inside the branch, customers remain caught between hope and uncertainty.

CM  
YK



The Return Regulation approves the deportation of irregular immigrants to third-party countries; states can now form agreements with non-EU countries and set up deportation centres there; even as European Commission head Ursula von der Leyen hailed the law as 'fair and firm', critics say it has 'little regard for people's safety, dignity and rights, and fails to uphold the EU's fundamental values'

## Super subs fire Switzerland past Bosnia and close in on last 32 spot



## Six-star Canada hammers Qatar into submission



## Alleyne's heroics hand West Indies thrilling victory over Scotland



## Prema replaces injured Shreyanka in India's T20 World Cup squad



CM  
YK

Weekend Sport

How pitches are laid, how they age, and why it's both art and science

Ever wondered why some tracks play true and others – like the recent Lord's strip – don't? Here is an explainer on the preparation of pitches and the factors that govern their behaviour

Vasudevan Mukunth

In the first week of June, a men's Test between England and New Zealand lasted just 166 overs, prompting unpleasant comments about the variable bounce of the Lord's surface. While no curator intentionally sets up bad wickets, what does go wrong when a pitch goes wrong?

What is a pitch made of?

A cricket pitch is clay, water, and grass. The clay supplies the hardness, the grass provides the strength, and the water determines its pace.

Clay is a type of heavy soil composed mainly of aluminosilicate minerals. Clay particles are very small and flat, allowing them to slide past each other when they're wet or harden and bond when they're dry.

Curators generally choose between two main types of clay: black and red. Black soil mainly has smectite and montmorillonite minerals. It is common in Australia and parts of India. It is stickier and harder when dry, creating the wide cracks seen on day-5 pitches. But because the particles bind so tightly, the pitches can offer pace and bounce.

Red soil, more common in Chennai and some Caribbean islands, consists of kaolinite and illite. It doesn't crack as dramatically but tends to break into smaller, finer particles more quickly, leading to rough surfaces that help the ball grip for spin and facilitate reverse swing sooner in a match.

For all the control curators exercise, a cricket pitch is a living, changing thing – an aspect most pronounced during a Test

How is a pitch laid?

Curators begin by selecting and laying the soil to contain clay. In the U.K., pitch loams are typically 25-35% clay; this together with higher silt levels encourage the seaming conditions famous in England. In Australia, the soil can exceed 60% clay, creating the bounce of Perth and Brisbane. According to former pitch curator P.R. Viswanathan, the clay content in India is usually 50-60%.

Curators also use heavy rollers, weighing a few hundred kilograms to over a tonne, to apply a large amount of pressure when the soil has just the right amount of moisture, forcing the clay particles into their most packed arrangement.

Since a heavily rolled pitch will be smooth, a ball striking the surface will suffer less friction and retain more kinetic energy. This is part of why Curtly Ambrose was able to pick up seven wickets for just one run in a spell against Australia in Perth in 1993.

Finally, below the 100-150 mm of the wicketing layer lies the base. It usually consists of a layer of silt or sandy loam, then a layer of gravel or crushed stone. The base can't be too soft or it will absorb the ball's energy. If it is too hard, the pitch can heave or become uneven. Consistent bounce also requires the clay layer to be bonded to the base underneath.

In many modern multipurpose stadiums, curators develop pitches in large steel trays away from the stadium and drop them in before a season begins. Since they lack a natural

soil profile, they sometimes develop more predictable bounce.

What effect does water have?

To wet a pitch, according to the U.K. Grounds Management Association, curators use a process called deep saturation several days before a match to ensure moisture penetrates about 75-100 mm down, allowing the clay to settle and pack. This could take a day or more. Then the water is allowed to evaporate, so that capillary action pulls moisture up from deeper and dries the pitch uniformly.

The bounce comes from the soil's elasticity. A hard, bone-dry surface like Perth is highly elastic because it returns nearly all the energy to the ball, allowing it to climb. But on a damp pitch, moisture reduces friction and the ball skids through – but the water also softens the clay, reducing its elasticity and forcing the ball to stay low.

Recently, the Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC) pioneered a technique called soil-steaming to remove pests attacking the grass's roots at Lord's. A contractor injected superheated steam into the soil square, killing harmful microbes and weeds to several centimetres without any chemical residue. Once the roots were healthy again, the thinking went, the clay would bind better to render a more bouncy surface.

However, ESPNcricinfo reported the steaming efforts appeared "to have had minimal positive effect on the evidence of the first two days" of the England-New Zealand contest.

What role does grass play?

Aside from sinking roots into the pitch that reinforce the soil, blades of grass above the sur-

face – which curators typically cut to be 3-5 mm high, according to pitch consultant Andy Atkinson – provide friction against the ball. In particular, the blades interact with the ball's seam: if the pitch is lush, the seam can 'grip' the blades and deviate sideways.

But if curators have shaved the grass off, the seam would catch almost nothing. However, as the game wears on and one side of the ball becomes scuffed, the pitch will also increase friction on the leather and allow the ball to reverse-swing.

Grass also helps control the pitch's wetness as its roots draw water from deeper soil layers and release it through the leaves. This can help ensure the pitch isn't like a moist cake with a hard crust.

Grass helps control the pitch's wetness as its roots draw water from deeper soil layers and release it through the leaves. This can help ensure the pitch isn't like a moist cake with a hard crust

The Sabina Park Test match in 1998 was abandoned after only 10.1 overs because, from the same spot on the pitch, balls bowled by the West Indies quicks either reared sharply at the England batters or skidded fast and low. The inquiries that followed concluded that the pitch hadn't fully settled before the match and may have been like the aforementioned cake.

Why does a pitch deteriorate?

For all the control curators exercise, a cricket pitch is a living, changing thing – an aspect most pronounced during a Test. After curators lay a pitch for the opening day, they anticipate the sun, the humidity, and the winds will shape its devolution over the next 450 overs.

The manner of decay depends on the clay, according to the 2023 book *Cricket Pitches: The Science Behind the Art of Pitch-Making*. On a black-soil pitch, the clay will pull apart into islands: if a ball hits the edge of one of these cracks, it can behave dangerously. A red-soil pitch deteriorates more uniformly: the top layer turns to powder, scuffing the ball's leather and allowing spinners to find more purchase even sans large cracks.

A good example of 'controlled deterioration' was the Australia v. South Africa women's Test at Perth in 2024: curator Isaac McDonald ensured the pitch dried slowly, allowing the clay to settle into dense blocks rather than crack. Second, his team maintained a slim carpet of live grass on the pitch, preventing the top surface from breaking up into dust.

On the other hand, the bounce troubles at Lord's often stem from the U.K. soils' clay shortfall; the clay particles also don't bind very durably. If the weather is also inconsistent, the pitch can develop soft spots under a hard crust, resulting in variable bounce.



STACKING UP



**ATP Men's Top 15**

| #  | Player                | Age | Points | Events |
|----|-----------------------|-----|--------|--------|
| 1  | Jannik Sinner         | 24  | 13,500 | 19     |
| 2  | Carlos Alcaraz        | 23  | 9,960  | 18     |
| 3  | Alexander Zverev      | 29  | 7,190  | 20     |
| 4  | Felix Auger-Aliassime | 25  | 4,390  | 24     |
| 5  | Ben Shelton           | 23  | 4,070  | 23     |
| 6  | Alex de Minaur        | 27  | 4,060  | 24     |
| 7  | Daniil Medvedev       | 30  | 3,810  | 24     |
| 8  | Novak Djokovic        | 39  | 3,760  | 16     |
| 9  | Taylor Fritz          | 28  | 3,635  | 23     |
| 10 | Flavio Cobolli        | 24  | 3,540  | 27     |
| 11 | Alexander Bublik      | 28  | 3,020  | 26     |
| 12 | Jiri Lehecka          | 24  | 2,640  | 21     |
| 13 | Andrey Rublev         | 28  | 2,460  | 23     |
| 14 | Casper Ruud           | 27  | 2,425  | 22     |
| 15 | Lorenzo Musetti       | 24  | 2,315  | 23     |

**Top Indians ▶**



Sumit Nagal  
Rank 277 ▲ 1 spot



Manas Dhamne  
Rank 378 ▼ 5 spots



**F1 Drivers' standings**

| #  | Driver         | Team         | Points | Wins |
|----|----------------|--------------|--------|------|
| 1  | A.K. Antonelli | Mercedes     | 156    | 5    |
| 2  | L. Hamilton    | Ferrari      | 115    | 1    |
| 3  | G. Russell     | Mercedes     | 106    | 1    |
| 4  | C. Leclerc     | Ferrari      | 75     | 0    |
| 5  | L. Norris      | McLaren      | 73     | 0    |
| 6  | O. Piastri     | McLaren      | 68     | 0    |
| 7  | M. Verstappen  | Red Bull     | 55     | 0    |
| 8  | P. Gasly       | Alpine       | 41     | 0    |
| 9  | I. Hadjar      | Red Bull     | 34     | 0    |
| 10 | L. Lawson      | RB           | 28     | 0    |
| 11 | O. Bearman     | Haas         | 18     | 0    |
| 12 | F. Colapinto   | Alpine       | 16     | 0    |
| 13 | A. Lindblad    | RB           | 13     | 0    |
| 14 | C. Sainz       | Williams     | 6      | 0    |
| 15 | A. Albon       | Williams     | 5      | 0    |
| 16 | E. Ocon        | Haas         | 3      | 0    |
| 17 | G. Bortoleto   | Audi         | 2      | 0    |
| 18 | F. Alonso      | Aston Martin | 1      | 0    |
| 19 | N. Hulkenberg  | Audi         | 0      | 0    |
| 20 | V. Bottas      | Cadillac     | 0      | 0    |
| 21 | S. Perez       | Cadillac     | 0      | 0    |
| 22 | L. Stroll      | Aston Martin | 0      | 0    |



A.K. Antonelli



L. Hamilton



**WTA Women's Top 15**

| #  | Player           | Age | Points | Events |
|----|------------------|-----|--------|--------|
| 1  | Aryna Sabalenka  | 28  | 9,090  | 19     |
| 2  | Elena Rybakina   | 26  | 8,143  | 22     |
| 3  | Iga Swiatek      | 25  | 6,733  | 19     |
| 4  | Jessica Pegula   | 32  | 6,056  | 20     |
| 5  | Mirra Andreeva   | 19  | 5,751  | 21     |
| 6  | Amanda Anisimova | 24  | 5,631  | 16     |
| 7  | Coco Gauff       | 22  | 4,879  | 19     |
| 8  | Elina Svitolina  | 31  | 4,315  | 15     |
| 9  | Victoria Mboko   | 19  | 3,670  | 22     |
| 10 | Karolina Muchova | 29  | 3,388  | 18     |
| 11 | Belinda Bencic   | 29  | 3,385  | 19     |
| 12 | Marta Kostyuk    | 23  | 3,157  | 19     |
| 13 | Linda Noskova    | 21  | 3,054  | 22     |
| 14 | Jasmine Paolini  | 30  | 2,617  | 20     |
| 15 | Naomi Osaka      | 28  | 2,571  | 20     |

**Top Indians ▶**



Sahaja Yamalapalli  
Rank 332 ▼ 1 spot



Vaishnavi Adkar  
Rank 396 ▼ 22 spots



**F1 Constructors' standings**

| Pos | Team         | Points | Wins |
|-----|--------------|--------|------|
| 1   | Mercedes     | 262    | 6    |
| 2   | Ferrari      | 190    | 1    |
| 3   | McLaren      | 141    | 0    |
| 4   | Red Bull     | 89     | 0    |
| 5   | Alpine       | 57     | 0    |
| 6   | RB           | 41     | 0    |
| 7   | Haas         | 21     | 0    |
| 8   | Williams     | 11     | 0    |
| 9   | Audi         | 2      | 0    |
| 10  | Aston Martin | 1      | 0    |
| 11  | Cadillac     | 0      | 0    |



**Badminton Men's ranking**

| #  | Player             | Points   | Events |
|----|--------------------|----------|--------|
| 1  | Shi Yu Qi          | 1,05,305 | 12     |
| 2  | Kunlavut Vitidsarn | 92,565   | 16     |
| 3  | Anders Antonsen    | 91,155   | 17     |
| 4  | Jonatan Christie   | 88,431   | 17     |
| 5  | Christo Popov      | 84,682   | 20     |
| 6  | Chou Tien Chen     | 80,280   | 27     |
| 7  | Alex Lanier        | 74,525   | 17     |
| 8  | Li Shi Feng        | 73,083   | 16     |
| 9  | Victor Lai         | 72,915   | 21     |
| 10 | Alwi Farhan        | 70,369   | 20     |
| 11 | Kodai Naraoka      | 68,020   | 21     |
| 12 | Lin Chun-Yi        | 66,594   | 18     |
| 13 | Loh Kean Yew       | 65,700   | 18     |
| 14 | Lakshya Sen        | 65,213   | 22     |
| 15 | Weng Hong Yang     | 59,341   | 17     |

**Top Indians ▶**



Lakshya Sen  
Rank 14



Ayush Shetty  
Rank 21



**Badminton Women's ranking**

| #  | Player               | Points   | Events |
|----|----------------------|----------|--------|
| 1  | An Se Young          | 1,17,787 | 16     |
| 2  | Wang Zhi Yi          | 1,06,839 | 16     |
| 3  | Akane Yamaguchi      | 1,00,426 | 18     |
| 4  | Chen Yu Fei          | 87,651   | 16     |
| 5  | Han Yue              | 82,288   | 14     |
| 6  | Putri Kusuma Wardani | 73,473   | 18     |
| 7  | Ratchanok Intanon    | 72,246   | 20     |
| 8  | Pornpawee Chochuwong | 67,977   | 16     |
| 9  | Tomoka Miyazaki      | 63,646   | 22     |
| 10 | Pusarla V. Sindhu    | 61,401   | 14     |
| 11 | Nozomi Okuhara       | 59,060   | 20     |
| 12 | Chiu Pin-Chian       | 57,498   | 25     |
| 13 | Michelle Li          | 55,227   | 20     |
| 14 | Mia Blichfeldt       | 53,503   | 15     |
| 15 | Sim Yu Jin           | 53,354   | 10     |

**Top Indians ▶**



P.V. Sindhu  
Rank 10



Unnati Hooda  
Rank 24



**Test Batting**

| #  | Player           | Rating | Career best |
|----|------------------|--------|-------------|
| 1  | Harry Brook      | 869    | 898         |
| 2  | Travis Head      | 853    | 884         |
| 3  | Joe Root         | 851    | 932         |
| 4  | Steve Smith      | 831    | 947         |
| 5  | Kamindu Mendis   | 781    | 784         |
| 6  | Kane Williamson  | 780    | 919         |
| 7  | Temba Bavuma     | 775    | 806         |
| 8  | Shubman Gill     | 743    | 807         |
| 9  | Yashasvi Jaiswal | 733    | 858         |
| 10 | Dinesh Chandimal | 717    | 755         |

**ODI Batting**

| #  | Player           | Rating | Career best |
|----|------------------|--------|-------------|
| 1  | Daryl Mitchell   | 815    | 840         |
| 2  | Virat Kohli      | 783    | 908         |
| 3  | Ibrahim Zadran   | 741    | 756         |
| 4  | Rohit Sharma     | 739    | 879         |
| 5  | Shubman Gill     | 735    | 841         |
| 6  | Babar Azam       | 689    | 894         |
| 7  | Shai Hope        | 683    | 782         |
| 8  | Harry Tector     | 679    | 730         |
| 9  | K.L. Rahul       | 669    | 676         |
| 10 | Charith Asalanka | 659    | 705         |



**Test Bowling**

| #  | Player         | Rating | Career best |
|----|----------------|--------|-------------|
| 1  | Jasprit Bumrah | 870    | 908         |
| 2  | Mitchell Starc | 838    | 852         |
| 3  | Pat Cummins    | 832    | 914         |
| 4  | Marco Jansen   | 825    | 825         |
| 5  | Scott Boland   | 820    | 820         |
| 6  | Noman Ali      | 817    | 853         |
| 7  | Matt Henry     | 812    | 853         |
| 8  | Kagiso Rabada  | 807    | 902         |
| 9  | Josh Hazlewood | 775    | 864         |
| 10 | Gus Atkinson   | 754    | 766         |

**ODI Bowling**

| #  | Player             | Rating | Career best |
|----|--------------------|--------|-------------|
| 1  | Rashid Khan        | 696    | 775         |
| 2  | Abrar Ahmed        | 675    | 675         |
| 3  | Jofra Archer       | 649    | 682         |
| 4  | Keshav Maharaj     | 645    | 737         |
| 5  | Maheesh Theekshana | 641    | 680         |
| 6  | Adil Rashid        | 629    | 671         |
| 7  | Kuldeep Yadav      | 618    | 757         |
| 8  | Mehidy Hasan       | 604    | 722         |
| 9  | Shaheen Afridi     | 604    | 691         |
| 10 | Mitchell Santner   | 599    | 656         |



**T20I Batting**

| #  | Player           | Rating | Career best |
|----|------------------|--------|-------------|
| 1  | Abhishek Sharma  | 875    | 931         |
| 2  | Ishan Kishan     | 871    | 871         |
| 3  | Sahibzada Farhan | 848    | 848         |
| 4  | Phil Salt        | 792    | 881         |
| 5  | Pathum Nissanka  | 751    | 796         |
| 6  | Tilak Varma      | 742    | 845         |
| 7  | Suryakumar Yadav | 722    | 912         |
| 8  | Jos Buttler      | 716    | 794         |
| 9  | Dewald Brevis    | 702    | 738         |
| 10 | Brian Bennett    | 701    | 708         |



**T20I Bowling**

| #  | Player              | Rating | Career best |
|----|---------------------|--------|-------------|
| 1  | Rashid Khan         | 753    | 828         |
| 2  | Varun Chakaravarthy | 740    | 818         |
| 3  | Abrar Ahmed         | 736    | 757         |
| 4  | Adil Rashid         | 721    | 747         |
| 5  | Jasprit Bumrah      | 702    | 783         |
| 6  | Adam Zampa          | 682    | 746         |
| 7  | Corbin Bosch        | 669    | 745         |
| 8  | Wanindu Hasaranga   | 668    | 809         |
| 9  | Mujeeb Ur Rahman    | 663    | 757         |
| 10 | Nathan Ellis        | 661    | 678         |

